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COVER STORY

Chinese Traffic to time.gif

So this might just be an attempted Denial of Service (DoS) attack?

Dennis Felsing

Nearly two years ago I posted this endless GIF that always shows the current time in UTC:

Now looking at my GoAccess dashboard I can see that it is picking up in popularity rather suddenly:

But strangely I can't find anything about time.gif being linked on the web. So this might just be an attempted Denial of Service (DoS) attack? At least that would be something I am familiar with from the DDNet direction, but it's certainly strange on HookRace. But instead of simply shutting down time.gif I decided to try to find out who is accessing it and whether I can keep the server up.

Let's look into the nginx logs, since I use nginx to proxy the requests to the Haskell program. There I see about 40 new requests per second looking like this:

```
class="highlight"> hookrace.net 123.185. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 3335 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (Linux; Android 8.1.0; V1818A Build/OPM1.171019.026; wv) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/4.0 Chrome/66.0.3359.126 MQQBrowser/6.2 TBS/044681 Mobile Safari/537.36 MMWEBID/XXX MicroMessenger/7.0.4.1420(0x2700043A) Process/tools NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 8.055
```

```
hookrace.net 111.62. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 32061 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (Linux; Android 5.1; OPPO A59s Build/LMY47I; wv) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/4.0 Chrome/66.0.3359.126 MQQBrowser/6.2 TBS/044704 Mobile Safari/537.36 MMWEBID/XXX MicroMessenger/7.0.4.1420(0x2700043B) Process/tools NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 89.256
```

```
hookrace.net 111.29. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 543830 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (Linux; Android 7.1.1; OPPO R11 Build/
```

```
NMF26X; wv) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/4.0 Chrome/66.0.3359.126 MQQBrowser/6.2 TBS/044704 Mobile Safari/537.36 MMWEBID/XXX MicroMessenger/7.0.4.1420(0x2700043A) Process/tools NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 1540.238
```

```
hookrace.net 112.2. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 172102 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (Linux; Android 8.1.0; V1816A Build/OPM1.171019.011; wv) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/4.0 Chrome/66.0.3359.126 MQQBrowser/6.2 TBS/044611 Mobile Safari/537.36 MMWEBID/XXX MicroMessenger/7.0.4.1420(0x2700043A) Process/tools NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 492.600
```

```
hookrace.net 123.13. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 1275 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (Linux; Android 9; LYA-AL00 Build/HUAWEILYA-AL00L; wv) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/4.0 Chrome/66.0.3359.126 MQQBrowser/6.2 TBS/044704 Mobile Safari/537.36 MMWEBID/XXX MicroMessenger/7.0.4.1420(0x2700043A) Process/tools NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 1.888
```

```
hookrace.net 117.91. XXX. XXX - - [21/May/2019:21:21:27 +0200] "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0" 200 4684 "XXX" "Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 12_1_4 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/605.1.15 (KHTML, like Gecko) Mobile/16D57 MicroMessenger/7.0.3(0x17000321) NetType/WIFI Language/zh_CN" 12.123
```

I checked a few IP addresses and they were all in mobile networks, not data centers. The user agent containing MicroMessenger and MQQBrowser indicates that the source of the traffic are WeChat and/or QQ, popular chinese chat apps.

id="quantifying-the-traffic">Quantifying the Traffic

For reference, the system I'm running on is a simple Debian based VPS with 2 threads and 2 GB of RAM that also functions as the main server for DDNet's website, database and my HookRace blog.

I already had to do some scaling when posting the initial blog post on Hacker News, optimizing the Haskell application itself to use LZW encoding in the GIF frames, to properly clean up connections to prevent any memory leaks and disable buffering in nginx's config.

But the current level of traffic is on a different scale with 2.4 million hits on time.gif in the last 23 hours (30 hits per second) resulting in 113 GB of data being transferred. And many of those connections don't finish quickly, instead they linger for seconds, minutes or even hours.

Using `ls -li | grep Time | wc -l` I can see that there are about 6000 people downloading the GIF at peak times, causing up to 30 Mbit/s of outgoing traffic with 7000 packets/second incoming and the same number outgoing. The DDNet server statistics lets me monitor this nicely (related blog article):

Network

Packets

CPU

id="keeping-up-with-the-traffic">Keeping Up with the Traffic

Regenerating the ranks pages of DDNet usually causes the main CPU load on the server, which can be seen in the above CPU graph as spikes. This task is already set to only run when the server is below a specified load, so that more essential tasks have priority.

The first new problem was nginx running into a limit of 768 worker_connections:

```
class="highlight"> 2019/05/20 20:41:30 [alert] 761#761:
*3828093 768 worker_connections are not enough while
connecting to upstream, client: 49.114. XXX. XXX,
server: hookrace.net, request: "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0",
upstream: "http://127.0.0.1:5002/", host: "hookrace.net", re-
ferrer: "XXX"
```

Luckily that is easily fixed in `/etc/nginx/nginx.conf` by increasing the number of worker_connections to keep alive, each of which is handling one of the long-lasting time.gif requests:

```
events { worker_connections 20000 ; }
```

and `systemctl reload nginx`. No downtime required since nginx will start new worker processes to handle new requests while keeping the old ones alive for a time to keep handling existing connections.

Unfortunately that fix only lasted a few hours until the next problem appeared:

```
class="highlight"> 2019/05/20 23:09:21 [alert] 15188#15188:
*4041619 socket() failed (24: Too many open files)
while connecting to upstream, client: 27.207. XXX. XXX,
server: hookrace.net, request: "GET /time.gif HTTP/2.0",
upstream: "http://127.0.0.1:5002/", host: "hookrace.net", re-
ferrer: "XXX"
```

Increasing the limits in `/etc/security/limits.conf` for the nginx user fixes this:

The value of 1048576 is chosen since it's the value set in `sysctl fs.file-max` and it should be good enough for now.

Next I noticed that the server was running out of memory with both the Haskell application and nginx having to keep track of so many connections at once. For now I increased the swap size on the fly to keep some less commonly used stuff there using `dd if=/dev/zero of=/var/swap bs=1M count=5000 && mkswap /var/swap && swapon /var/swap`.

When running out of memory I noticed that Python's msgpack implementation fails quite confusingly when it runs OOM. So I had to add some fixes to the code creating the DDNet ranks pages to handle this possibility.

The Linux Kernel's TCP buffers ran out of memory next, complaining in dmesg:

So I increased them with a `net.ipv4.tcp_mem = 116730 155640 233460` in `/etc/sysctl.conf` and reloaded it with `sysctl -p`.

A limitation of my current approach is the number of ports nginx can open to proxy to the Haskell application. If that gets blown I'll have to communicate to the application differently or simply redirect to the application directly instead of proxying it. That would also reduce the CPU load significantly, cutting out nginx which happens to be much more expensive than the Haskell application, probably because it's also handling TLS.

id="final-words">Final Words

While it was fun to keep time.gif running in the face of this amount of traffic, I still haven't answered the final question of where this traffic is coming from. It might be that lots of Chinese happen to be spreading time.gif on WeChat and QQ, but for that the traffic looks a bit too sterile. Has anyone seen similar traffic patterns and might know if they are real or some kind of botnet? Maybe someone has embedded traffic.gif on some WeChat-specific page. If anyone has a clue please drop me an email at dennis@felsing.org.

Hi,

I read your post and this is just my guess:

Chinese “WhatsApp” type of communication culture is very strange. They are like spam emails in the old days. Often time some one might create posts in picture, eg include warm message such as reminding each other to put on more clothes as the weather is getting cold, etc.

My guess is then someone read your trick and thought that it is a good idea to create some picture that always show the current time. Eg to remind others that it is time to sleep or something.

And like email spams in the old days, people can share things like this crazily, often by older people who don't know much about technology. (Just like how some tweet can go viral, messages like this could also go viral within there networks. And unfortunately the viral thing we often received are really rubbish like.)

yours,

Discuss on Hacker News .

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FEATURES

This Is a Poem That Heals Fish: An Almost Unbearably Wonderful Picture-Book About How Poetry Works Its Magic

Maria Popova · *The Marginalian* (Brain Pickings)

“A poem ... is when you are in love and have the sky in your mouth.”

“Poetry can break open locked chambers of possibility, restore numbed zones to feeling, recharge desire,” Adrienne Rich wrote in contemplating the cultural power of poetry. But what is a poem, really, and what exactly is its use?

Every once in a while, you stumble upon something so lovely, so unpretentiously beautiful and quietly profound, that you feel like the lungs of your soul have been pumped with a mighty gasp of Alpine air. This Is a Poem That Heals Fish (public library) is one such vitalizing gasp of loveliness — a lyrical picture-book that offers a playful and penetrating answer to the question of what a poem is and what it does. And as it does that, it shines a sidewise gleam on the larger question of what we most hunger for in life and how we give shape to those deepest longings.

Written by the French poet, novelist, and dramatist Jean-Pierre Simeón, translated into English by Enchanted Lion Books founder Claudia Zoe Bedrick (the feat of translation which the Nobel-winning Polish poet Wisława Szymborska had in mind when she spoke of “that rare miracle when a translation stops being a translation and becomes ... a second original”), and illustrated by the inimitable Olivier Tallec, this poetic and philosophical tale follows young Arthur as he tries to salve his beloved red fish Leon’s affliction of boredom.

Arthur’s mommy looks at him.

She closes her eyes,

she opens her eyes...

Then she smiles:

— Hurry, give him a poem!

And she leaves for her tuba lesson.

Puzzled and unsure what a poem is, Arthur goes looking in the pantry, only to hear the noodles sigh that there is no poem there. He searches in the closet and under his bed, but the vacuum cleaner and the dust balls have no poem, either.

Determined, Arthur continues his search.

He runs to Lolo’s bicycle shop.

Lolo knows everything, laughs all the time, and is always in love.

He is repairing a tire and singing.

So begins the wonderful meta-story of how poetry comes into being as a tapestry of images, metaphors, and magpie borrowings. Each person along the way contributes to Arthur’s tapestry a different answer, infused with the singular poetic truth of his or her own life. Lolo offers:

— A poem, Arthur, is when you are in love and have the sky in your mouth.

— Oh...? Okay.

Next, he visits his friend the baker, Mrs. Round, who echoes Thom Gunn’s insistence that “poetry is of many sorts and is all around us,” rather than something reserved for the special formal class of “poets.”

Mrs. Round tells Arthur:

— A poem? I don’t know much about that.

But I know one, and it is hot like fresh bread.

When you eat it, a little is always left over.

— Oh...? Okay.

Arthur turns to his neighbor next, “old Mahmoud who comes from the desert and waters his rhododendrons every morning at 9 o’clock.”

” Mahmoud offers his answer with easeful conviction: — A poem is when you hear the heartbeat of a stone.

Maria Popova

Mahmoud offers his answer with easeful conviction:

— A poem is when you hear the heartbeat of a stone.

— Oh...? All right.

Arthur hastens home to check on poor Leon, who appears to be asleep, “floating gently amidst the seaweed as if thinking.” And because this is the sort of story in which a canary can only be named after an Ancient Greek comic playwright, Arthur next seeks an answer from his canary named Aristophanes, “who is no bird brain.”

Our imagination is left to ponder why, on the next page, the cage contains not the yellow canary but a red-haired woman, who sings Aristophanes’s answer. Perhaps she is a visual allusion to Aristophanes’s play *Assemblywomen*, or perhaps she represents a muse, whom Tallec invokes to remind us that the muse hides in many guises and reveals herself in the most improbable of places.

— A poem is when words beat their wings.

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Meet the 2026 class of TED Fellows

TED Staff · TED Blog

For TED Fellows, hope isn't abstract — it's built through action. Across research labs and rural farms, courtrooms and classrooms, more than 500 Fellows in 100+ countries are reimagining the systems that shape our lives — climate and health, justice and education, art and technology. Together, they are repairing and redesigning the world into one that is more just, imaginative and alive with possibility.

For more than 17 years, the TED Fellows program has served as a launchpad for builders and visionaries. Through hands-on communication training, access to a global network of peers and mentors, and amplification across TED's platforms, Fellows gain the tools and visibility to transform their work into real-world impact.

We are thrilled to announce the 2026 class of TED Fellows, whose work spans four continents and nine countries. Among them: a philosopher challenging our growing reliance on AI prediction, a vaccine inventor preparing the world for future pandemics, a technologist preserving and verifying media that documents human rights abuses, and Japan's youngest-ever mayor reshaping democracy.

Meet the new Fellows below, and join us in welcoming them to the TED community:

Carissa Véliz

Philosopher, AI ethicist | Mexico + Spain + UK

Carissa Véliz is a professor at Oxford University researching humanity's overreliance on prediction — from AI algorithms to political polling. In her latest book, *Prophecy*, she argues that predictions undermine democracy, eroding privacy and replacing human judgment.

Activist, guitarist, composer | Mexico + US

Fabi Reyna is a cultural activist and composer working with music as a tool for communication, investigation and sociopolitical resilience. As the founder of She Shreds Media and the creative behind the band Reyna Tropical, they offer spaces where underrepresented and diasporic people can unify and thrive.

Researcher Felix Hol holds a mosquito cage, used to collect malaria-carrying mosquitoes from people's homes near Kalongo, Northern Uganda. Working with local teams of "mosquito hunters," he studies how the insects adapt their behavior — like shifting when they bite — to circumvent prevention tools such as bed nets.

Mosquito biotechnologist | Netherlands

Felix Hol is an assistant professor at Radboud University Medical Center, investigating mosquito behavior — from what they taste on our skin to why they now bite earlier in

the day. By turning these insights into simple, open-source tools, he helps communities prevent harmful diseases.

Biomedical innovator | US

As cofounder and CEO of Revalia Bio, Greg Tietjen revives donated, transplantable human organs and tissues, transforming them into powerful tools for biomedical research. By integrating medicine, engineering and data science, his team uses these living organs as a foundation to accelerate new drug development while lowering costs.

Digital evidence technologist | Syria

As founder and managing director of Mnemonic, Hadi Al Khatib develops systems that collect and preserve citizen-generated digital media documenting human rights abuses. By verifying this open-source material as credible evidence, his work enables communities in Syria, Sudan, Ukraine and beyond to pursue justice and protect democracy.

Kizzmekia Corbett-Helaire

Immunologist, vaccine inventor | US

A key inventor of COVID-19 vaccine technology, Kizzmekia Corbett-Helaire leads a research lab at Harvard University. She develops vaccines and therapeutics for emerging viruses and educates the public on vaccine science to ensure humanity is ready for the next pandemic.

Japan's youngest-ever mayor | Japan

At the age of 26, Ryosuke Takashima became the youngest person to win a mayoral seat in Japan, sparking a new wave of young leaders in government. He invites citizens to participate in reforming their communities, spearheading education and climate policy as well as strengthening technological infrastructure.

Manufacturing innovator | Haiti + US

Cofounder and CEO of Rapid Liquid Print, Schendy Kernizan invented a mold-free, gel-suspension manufacturing process with his team at MIT, making products more affordable, accessible and sustainable. From medicine to transportation to space exploration, his innovation is transforming industries.

Economic justice advocate | US

As a leader in California's public banking movement, Trinity Tran helps cities redirect funds from big banks into affordable housing, small businesses and critical infrastructure. By passing first-in-the-nation legislation in the United States, she is empowering communities to reclaim control of their own economies.

Dancer, choreographer | South Africa

Tushrik Fredericks is an award-winning choreographer and dancer who uses social dance and movement to express

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Here's how to live: Master something.

Derek Sivers

Be a monomaniac on a mission to be truly great at something difficult.

Pick one thing and spend the rest of your life getting deeper into it.

Mastery is the best goal because the rich can't buy it, the impatient can't rush it, the privileged can't inherit it, and nobody can steal it.

You can only earn it through hard work.

Mastery is the ultimate status.

Striving makes you happy.

Pursuit is the opposite of depression.

People at the end of their life, who said they were the happiest with their life, were the ones who had spent the most time in the flow of fascinating work.

Concentrating all of your life's force on one thing gives you incredible power.

Sunlight won't catch a stick on fire.

But if you use a magnifying glass to focus the sunlight on one spot, it will.

Mastery needs your full focused attention.

The more you learn about something, the more there is to learn.

You see what normal people don't see.

The path gets more and more interesting as you go.

The pursuit of mastery helps you think long-term.

It keeps your eyes on the horizon.

You resist the temptation of what you want now.

You remember the importance of what you want most.

You spend time intentionally.

Every month has a milestone.

Every day has a goal.

The most rewarding things in life take years.

Only bad things happen quickly.

Decisions are easy when you have only one priority.

Your destination is a huge mountain peak on the horizon.

You can see it from everywhere.

Yes to that mountain, and no to everything else.

You'll always know where you're going, and what you're doing next.

All paths go either towards that mountain or away from it.

Because of this perspective, problems won't deter you.

Most people look down at the ground, upset by every obstacle.

With your eyes on the horizon, you'll step over obstacles, undeterred.

If you haven't decided what to master, pick anything that scares you, fascinates you, or infuriates you.

Don't ask, "Is this the real me?" or "Is this my passion?"

Those questions lead to endless searching and disappointment.

People don't fail by choosing the wrong path — they fail by not choosing.

Make your choice, then make a lifetime commitment to constant improvement.

The passion comes after you start getting good.

Define "success" for yourself.

Describe the outcome you want.

You can't hit a target you can't see.

You need to understand something very counter-intuitive about goals.

Goals don't improve your future.

Goals only improve your present actions.

A good goal makes you take action immediately.

A bad goal doesn't.

A goal shows what's right and wrong.

What moves you towards your goal is right.

What doesn't is wrong.

When you first start learning, you improve massively every week.

Beginning is fun.

But real expertise comes only after years of hard work.

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The Canadian World War 1 Hero: Leo Clarke, Victoria Cross

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Leo Clarke's story occupies a unique and almost mythic place in Canada's First World War memory, not only for the astonishing audacity of his Victoria Cross action but for the brevity and intensity of his life at war. In little more than two years, Clarke passed from civilian obscurity to battlefield legend, before being cut down almost immediately after his greatest triumph. His career encapsulates both the heroic ideal and the brutal indifference of industrial warfare, where courage could win a battle in one moment and mean nothing the next.

Born on the 1st December 1892 in the small community of Waterdown, Ontario, Leo Clarke grew up far removed from the violence that would define his fate. Like many young Canadians of his generation, he was raised in a society still closely tied to Britain, imbued with a sense of imperial duty and adventure. In his early adulthood, Clarke moved west, settling in Edmonton, Alberta, where he worked as a clerk. There is little to suggest that he was extraordinary in a conventional sense; he was not a career soldier, nor a product of military academies. Yet, like thousands of others, the outbreak of the First World War in August 1914 transformed his life almost overnight.

Clarke enlisted in the Canadian Expeditionary Force in 1915, joining the 2nd Battalion of the Canadian Infantry. By the time he reached the Western Front, the romantic notions of war had long since been obliterated by the realities of trench fighting. Mud, shellfire, and relentless casualties defined daily existence. Clarke quickly distinguished himself through aggressiveness and calm under fire, qualities that led to his promotion from the ranks to commissioned officer. By 1916, he held the rank of lieutenant, commanding men in one of the hardest-fought sectors of the front.

The summer and autumn of 1916 marked one of the bloodiest periods in Canadian military history. The Battle of the Somme, launched in July, had already claimed hundreds of thousands of casualties by the time Canadian units became deeply involved near Pozières and Courcellette. The battlefield was a shattered moonscape of shell holes, splintered trees, and pulverized trenches. Gains were measured in yards, often purchased at appalling cost. It was within this environment of attrition and exhaustion that Clarke performed the act for which he would be immortalized.

On the 9th of September 1916, near Pozières, Canadian troops were attempting to consolidate newly won ground when they were held up by a strongly defended German trench. The position posed a serious threat to the Canadian line, and delay meant exposure to counterattack. Rather than wait for orders or reinforcements, Clarke acted on his own initiative. Armed only with a revolver and a supply of grenades, he climbed out of his trench and leapt

onto the parapet of the German position, fully exposed to enemy fire.

What followed was an act of battlefield shock that bordered on the unbelievable. From his exposed position, Clarke hurled grenades down into the trench while firing his revolver at point-blank range. His sudden appearance and ferocity produced the illusion that a major assault was underway. German soldiers, stunned by the violence and speed of the attack, broke under the pressure. Clarke moved along the parapet alone, continuing his assault with relentless momentum, killing enemy soldiers and forcing others to surrender as he advanced.

The official Victoria Cross citation later recorded that Clarke killed nineteen German soldiers and captured thirty-three more, all without assistance. Just as crucially, his action neutralized a dangerous enemy position at a decisive moment, allowing Canadian forces to advance and secure the line with far fewer casualties than might otherwise have been expected. It was a moment where individual initiative directly altered the tactical situation, a rare but celebrated phenomenon in the mechanized slaughter of the Somme.

The award of the Victoria Cross recognized not only Clarke's courage but the extraordinary independence of his action. At a time when battlefield success increasingly depended on artillery barrages and coordinated infantry advances, Clarke's lone assault seemed almost an anachronism, recalling earlier ideals of personal gallantry. Yet it was precisely this unpredictability that made his action effective. In a war of routine and repetition, shock and audacity could still break the deadlock, if only briefly.

Clarke's Victoria Cross was gazetted later in 1916, and his deed was widely reported in Canadian newspapers. He became a symbol of Canadian bravery at the front, proof that the young Dominion was producing soldiers equal to any in the British Empire. But the attention and honor came too late to alter his fate. The Somme continued to consume lives indiscriminately, and Clarke remained with his battalion in the line. On the 19th of October 1916, scarcely six weeks after his legendary assault, Clarke was killed in action near Desire Trench during ongoing operations on the Somme. While leading his men under heavy fire, he was struck by a sniper's bullet and died almost instantly. He was just twenty-three years old. There was no dramatic final stand, no heroic flourish to match his Victoria Cross action—only the abrupt, unceremonious end that claimed so many young officers of the Great War.

Clarke's death underscores the cruel paradox at the heart of First World War heroism. Acts of extraordinary bravery could win medals and momentary advantage, but they offered no immunity from the random violence of the battlefield. His life and death illustrate how thin the margin was between legend and loss, and how fleeting individual triumph could be amid the vast machinery of modern war. Today, Leo Clarke is remembered as one of Canada's youngest Victoria Cross recipients and as a figure emblem-

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Gardening as Resistance: Notes on Building Paradise

Maria Popova · *The Marginalian* (Brain Pickings)

“Can you plant a garden to stop a war? It depends how you think about time. It depends what you think a seed does, if it’s tossed into fertile soil.”

“The gardener digs in another time, without past or future, beginning or end... Here is the Amen beyond the prayer,” Derek Jarman wrote as he grieved his dying friends, faced his own death, and contemplated art, mortality, and resistance while planting a garden between an old lighthouse and a new nuclear plant on a barren shingled shore.

Jarman is one of the artists whom Olivia Laing profiles and celebrates in *Funny Weather: Art in an Emergency* (public library) — her superb collection of meditations on art, activism, and our search for meaning, drawing on the lives of artists whose vision has changed the way we see the world, ourselves, and others.

Laing’s Jarman-fomented essay, titled “Paradise,” begins with the question of whether gardening is a form of art and ends with the question of whether art is a form of resistance — a necessary tool for building the Garden of Eden we imagine a flourishing society to be.

She writes:

Gardening situates you in a different kind of time, the antithesis of the agitating present of social media. Time becomes circular, not chronological; minutes stretch into hours; some actions don’t bear fruit for decades. The gardener is not immune to attrition and loss, but is daily confronted by the ongoing good news of fecundity. A peony returns, alien pink shoots thrusting from bare soil. The fennel self-seeds; there is an abundance of cosmos out of nowhere.

To bridge Laing’s two questions, one must somehow reconcile these two temporal models: linear time, which the Greek called *chronos* and along which we plot the vector of progress, and cyclical time, or *kairos*, which is the time of gardens and, Laing intimates, the time of societies. We long for the assurance of steady progression, yet all around us the rest of nature churns in cycles. How do the cicadas know when to awake from their seventeen-year slumbers and rise up by the billions to make new life that will in turn repeat the cycle? And the migratory birds, “how can they know that it’s time to go?” as Nina Simone asked in her serenade to time — Nina Simone, who also chose to cover Pete Seeger’s “Turn! Turn! Turn! (To Everything There Is a Season)” and who gave all she had to a movement the central concerns of which have returned a life-season later with redoubled urgency, its fruits only just beginning to ripen in our lifetime.

Therein lies the paradox — how do we practice resistance if time is the substance we are made of, as Borges so timelessly observed, and yet we live suspended between these two parallel versions of time as we try to build paradise?

“Resistance” has always been a funny word to me — one without direct translation in my native Bulgarian, in this particular context of constructive social change. It contours something necessary but not sufficient — while ennobling and empowering in its implication of defying wrongness, it limits its own power by ending at what is to be eradicated, without indication of what is to be grown in its place and how. In this respect, the resistance approach to human nature (and the consensual collective byproduct of human natures we call society) is like the pesticide approach to nature.

“Resistance” is a word especially limited by the elemental fact that there are certain things simply beyond the reach of resistance, impervious to our passions and protestations — spacetime, gravity, the fundamental laws that gave rise to our existence and will eventually return us to the stardust of which we are made. Your face will sag and your spine will bend under the twin assault of gravity and time, and so will mine, until our atoms disband altogether to become food for the worm and fertilizer for the mycelial wonderland from which bluebells will rise some future spring.

None of this we can resist.

But maybe — and that is what redeems and consecrates our finite human lives and our limited powers — within those parameters, there is space enough and spirit enough to resist what is poisonous to the ideological soil we call culture and persist in planting, for as long as we have to live and with as much generosity as we have to give, something lush and beautiful. That we might never live to see it bloom might just be okay. To have planted the seeds is satisfaction enough worth living for.

Laing lands in a kindred place. A century and a half after Thoreau contemplated the long cycles of social change and an increment after Zadie Smith reminded us that “progress is never permanent, will always be threatened, must be redoubled, restated and reimagined if it is to survive,” Laing writes after a pilgrimage to Derek Jarman’s grave:

Is art resistance? Can you plant a garden to stop a war? It depends how you think about time. It depends what you think a seed does, if it’s tossed into fertile soil. But it seems to me that whatever else you do, it’s worth tending to paradise, however you define it and wherever it arises.

The arc of the moral universe might not be so different from that of the stem bent with bluebells tolling their vernal reminder that change comes in cycles. Every arc, after all, is but a segment of a circle. What it takes to draw our share of it with a steady hand as we try “widening our circles of compassion” without the assurance of immediate results — that is the question we each answer with our lives.

Poet and gardener Ross Gay comes closest to my own answer in his life-tested conviction that time spent gardening is “an exercise in supreme attentiveness.” As I roll in my palm six large seedpods of sea kale — a neglected flowering wonder I discovered on the pages of Derek Jarman’s journal

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5 things we learned at day 1 of TEDNext 2025

Oliver Friedman · TED Blog

At the opening session of TEDNext 2025, we explored two big themes: wonder and wisdom. With speakers ranging from a digital artist and a biotech entrepreneur to an Oscar-winning costume designer and a world-famous ballerina, this session had it all.

What exactly is TEDNext? A vibrant, three-day exploration of what's next, propelling the “future you” to think expansively at every level, from personal to global. The second-ever TEDNext conference, held in Atlanta, continues an expansion of the annual slate of conferences from TED, with a conference designed to spark imagination, embrace possibility and foster dreams about what the next version of “you” can be.

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Some key takeaways from day 1:

We might be able to turn sunlight and CO₂ into lifesaving drugs. Humans learned to “program” biology nearly a century ago by inserting human genes into microbes, turning cells into tiny factories for life-saving drugs like insulin. Today, these methods are costly, resource-intensive and inaccessible to many, says physician and biotech entrepreneur David S. Kim . He presents a potential solution: by reprogramming a cell known as cyanobacteria, which feeds on sunlight and CO₂, we could unlock a sustainable “biological factory” for making medicines. He explains the science behind his team’s breakthrough and its potential to manufacture everything from food and fuels to materials and more.

Design is never neutral. What makes someone wicked? Costume designer Paul Tazewell probes this question in his work, demonstrating how clothing speaks a subconscious language that shapes who we view as heroes — and villains. From the period silhouettes of Hamilton and blending colors of West Side Story to the visual dualities of Wicked , Tazewell’s creations challenge stereotypes and inherited perceptions. His main message? If wickedness can be designed, then maybe we can redesign it together, too.

Media literacy is an essential skill of our time. With each leap of technology, humans have had to work double-time to keep up, says journalist and comedian Dave Jorgenson . He explains why media literacy — which he defines as “the ability to access, analyze, evaluate and create media in various forms” — is a crucial skill in an age of proliferating misinformation. With his own short, absurdist sketches that explain the news, he shows how humor can cut through fear, spark curiosity and cool down hot takes in order to explore nuanced truth.

The stage belongs to all of us. Ballerina and activist Misty Copeland made history in 2015 as the first Black woman

to become a principal dancer at the American Ballet Theatre. Just last month, she retired from the company with a farewell performance, dancing for a world she helped reshape. In a moving talk, she charts the quiet roots of resilience — nourished not by invulnerability but by persistently showing up despite pain, pressure and rejection. She shows how to transform “you don’t belong here” into “this stage is yours, too.”

Atlanta has serious moves. In an incredible mid-session performance, choreographer and cultural architect Sean Bankhead brought music to life through movement, dancing to “On My Mama” by Victoria Monét.

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The Romans in the Central Sahara: Cornelius Balbus' Expedition

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Cornelius Balbus' expedition into the heart of the central Sahara in 19 BCE reads like one of those stubborn footnotes that suddenly throws a spotlight on the limits and ambitions of Rome. Ordered during Augustus' long reign of consolidation, the campaign against the Garamantes, a long-established people centered in the Libyan Fezzān (with a capital often written as Garama or Germa), was not an attempt to annex a vast Saharan empire so much as a punitive and strategic effort: to punish raiding that menaced Roman North Africa, secure trans-Saharan trade routes, and demonstrate imperial reach beyond the familiar Mediterranean littoral.

Ancient literary sources record that Lucius (or sometimes rendered as Cornelius) Balbus celebrated a triumph in Rome after operations in the region, and later Roman authors, chiefly Pliny the Elder and writers summarized by Cassius Dio, place a handful of Garamantian settlements under Roman pressure or control around that time.

What actually happened on the ground and how far south Balbus' columns pushed, remains a matter for cautious reconstruction rather than neat storylines. Classical authors describe the Garamantes as a confederation that could strike along the coastal provinces and carry on a lively inland commerce; in 19 BCE the Romans, led by Balbus, are said to have captured multiple settlements and brought back evidence of victory to Rome, enough to earn a public triumph recorded on the Roman *fasti*.

Ancient historians framed the campaign as both corrective and economic: remove the threat of raids that harmed coastal cities such as Leptis Magna, and (if possible) open or safeguard commercial arteries feeding Roman markets. However, the surviving literary traces are short on operational detail and generous on Roman self-description, so scholarship treats the narratives as a starting point, not a literal map.

Archaeology has been invaluable in turning those literary hints into a more concrete picture of Garamantian power and how an outsider like Balbus might have engaged it. The Garamantes were far from the purely nomadic caricature of some classical writers: excavations and surveys across the Fazzān have exposed permanent settlements, cemeteries of distinctive tomb-pyramid forms, irrigation systems (the *foggaras* or qanat-like galleries) that tapped fossil aquifers, and networks of forts and farmed oases that made sedentary agriculture possible in the now hyper-arid landscape.

Satellite imagery and field survey in recent decades have revealed rings of forts and the outlines of defended centers in and around Germa. These Garamantian capital installations could be the objective or the spoils of a Roman punitive expedition. This material context helps explain why Romans would bother to project force into

the Sahara: the Garamantes controlled water, people, and routes that mattered to commerce and coastal security.

Direct archaeological evidence pointing specifically to Balbus' 19 BCE raid is necessarily limited. Unlike a campaign that left garrison forts with Latin inscriptions, the available material tends to show interaction rather than long-term occupation: imported Roman goods and amphorae found at Garamantian sites, references in Roman placards (the *Fasti Triumphales*) to Balbus' triumph, and the wider circulation of objects such as carnelian beads that testify to Saharan long-distance trade.

Scientific work tracing the sources of traded materials, for instance studies on carnelian provenance from the Fazzān supports the interpretation that the region was enmeshed in exchange networks linking sub-Saharan Africa, the Sahara, and the Mediterranean. In other words, archaeology corroborates the literary claim that Garamantian centers were prosperous and connected and therefore plausible targets for a high-profile Roman campaign even if it does not produce a single, unambiguous "Balbus layer" in the sand.

Modern archaeological narratives also complicate the older Roman story. Where some classical writers presented the Garamantes as perennial raiders, the material record shows complex, largely sedentary settlements with irrigation engineering that required organized labor and administration. Recent surveys and excavations argue for a polity that could sustain agriculture, fortifications and caravan ways.

Remote sensing, (the use of satellite imagery and aerial survey), has been especially transformative: archaeologists have mapped previously invisible lines of forts, settlement clusters and irrigation channels, revealing a landscape of infrastructure rather than scattered nomads. Those same tools have fed the debate over whether Roman operations produced any lasting control; most specialists now favor the view that Balbus' action was a decisive but short-term blow that destabilized and humiliated opponents without creating long-term Roman rule deep in the Sahara.

Putting the sources together produces a balanced verdict: Cornelius Balbus' 19 BCE expedition matters less because it produced an enduring Roman province than because it reveals how far Roman imperial ambition extended, and how Mediterranean powers interacted with African polities that were neither "primitive" nor marginal. The Romans used military theatre, political spectacle (the triumphal parade in Rome) and occasional force to regulate trade and security beyond their borders; the Garamantes, for their part, were sophisticated desert engineers and traders with the resources to attract Roman attention.

Archaeology has not so much confirmed every detail of the ancient accounts as given us a richer world in which to place them: a networked Sahara of wells and *foggaras*, fortified towns, and caravan routes, all of which

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The Kellogg Brothers: Health and Wellness Pioneers?

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

The Kellogg Brothers founded a powerful and impactful cereal company in 1906. They were also innovators in the health and wellness fields and were members of organizations that were ahead of their time - and fought against what was then considered a healthy lifestyle. The Kellogg Brothers left a lasting positive legacy on the health and wellness industry.

The Kellogg brothers' longest-lasting contribution to the Health industry is their product, Kellogg's Cornflakes. Dr. John Harvey Kellogg's (1852-1943) trek towards Kellogg's Cornflakes began as a search for a breakfast substitute to help treat his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium who were suffering from stomach problems. [1] This was a consistent complaint of his patients. A disabled gastrointestinal system caused the patient's stomach problems. Dr. Kellogg discovered that the half-baked breakfast mush he had previously been serving patients was causing dyspepsia. He also felt that the replacement should also be "pre-cooked". The creation of Kellogg's Corn Flakes involves conflicting accounts, in which, in the end, Dr. Kellogg, his wife, Ella, and Dr. Kellogg's brother, Will (1860-1951), should receive some credit for its creation. [2]

Dr. John Harvey Kellogg applied to the U. S. Patent Office for his patent on "Flaked Cereal and Process for Preparing the Same"(No.558,399) on May 31st, 1895. [3] The U. S. Patent Office granted Dr. Kellogg this patent on April 14th, 1896. In the patent itself, Dr. Kellogg included flakes made of oats, corn, barley, and other grains in addition to wheat flakes to protect his patent.

In the summer of 1895, Will and Dr. Kellogg introduced the Corn Flakes at the General Conference of the Seventh-Day Adventists at the Battle Creek Sanitarium. [4] The dish became a hit with conference attendees, who would add milk, cream, or yogurt to it.

In 1906, Will Kellogg founded the Battle Creek Toasted Corn Flake Company. [5] In 1907, he changed the company's name to the Kellogg Toasted Corn Flake Company. [6] In the late summer to early fall of 1907, Kellogg's Cornflakes made its official debut to the American public. [7] It was under Will Kellogg's leadership that, during the Great Depression in 1933, the Kellogg company made a gross profit of \$6 million (about \$110 million in today's money). [8] This was at a time when many companies were going bankrupt or struggling to maintain a profit. In 1939, Will Kellogg retired as the company's head.

Dr. Kellogg was also a trailblazer in other ways in the field of health and wellness. The Battle Creek Sanitarium began in 1866 as the Health Reform Institute. [9] "Sister" White presented her ideas about Christian biblical healthy living at the Seventh-day Adventist General Conference on May 20th, 1866. The General Conference approved the creation of an institute for health reform. [10] It was the

governing body of the Seventh-day Adventist Church. The organization opened its doors for business as The Western Health Reform Institution on September 5th, 1867. [11] On October 1st, 1876, Dr. Kellogg became the medical director of the Western Health Reform Institute. [12] The Western Health Reform Institute became the Battle Creek Sanatorium on September 15th, 1910. [13] On the same date, Dr. Kellogg told this audience how the new institution should be called Sanitarium or San, because he felt it better suited the mission. From 1876 to 1943, Dr. Kellogg was at the head of the Western Health Reform Institute, later known as the Battle Creek Sanitarium. [14] Several years before his death, Dr. Kellogg estimated that his work at the Sanitarium brought him into contact with approximately 250,000 persons. [15]

At the Battle Creek Sanitarium, if a patient were suffering from the "blues," they would be placed under an electric light cabinet to help them get sunlight. There was not much natural sunlight in southeastern Michigan during the Fall. [16] In this field, Dr. Kellogg was years ahead of his time in terms of medical treatment for seasonal affective disorder or SAD.

In 1916, at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, patient meals were also served with a card attached that specified the proper ratio of calories, proteins, carbohydrates, and fats to be consumed at the meal. [17] An example of this document is dated from May 19th, 1916. This was unheard of in the field of dieting and nutrition at the time.

Also at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, Dr. Kellogg would lead aerobics and calisthenics with the patients, backed by a brass band. [18] This was so popular that, in 1923, the Columbia Gramophone Company released 10 78-RPM shellac discs of Dr. Kellogg's class, complete with a booklet. The album was entitled "John Harvey Kellogg's HEALTH LADDER". In the booklet, there were exercises for the back, abdomen, legs, and arms that Dr. Kellogg recommended for his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium. This was decades ahead of the exercise craze led by Jack Lalanne, Richard Simmons, and other such international figures.

Although Dr. Kellogg never received credit for this, he encouraged his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, after surgery, to get up, move, and perform graded, deep-breathing exercises. [19] This was in stark contrast to the standard procedure of the day, which was to have patients confined to hospital beds for several days to weeks at a time. In the present day, medical procedures, early ambulation, and breathing exercises are the backbone of most recovery protocols after surgery.

In 1934, Dr. Kellogg received a patent for his "Soy Acidophilus Milk". [20] Dr. Kellogg devised this concoction to deal with babies who couldn't deal with cow's milk-based formulae, as well as his patients at the San who were suffering colitis, duodenal or gastric ulcers, babies who rejected their mom's breast milk, constipation, and excessive flatulence. This was a step forward in addressing digestive and

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walk and talk

Derek Sivers

Kevin Kelly invited me to walk 100 kilometers (62 miles) through northern Thailand for seven days, ending in Chiang Mai. Walking with us were ten other smart interesting people, including five other authors whose work I've loved for years. It's a "Walk and Talk".

One of the walkers lives in Thailand, speaks Thai, and made all the local arrangements, scoping the track in advance. Two of the walkers had done this many times before, in Uzbekistan, Spain, Japan, and China. The rest of us were in good hands, going with the flow of the unknown.

A sweet wild dog joined our pack halfway through, walking and sleeping with us for four days and 70km, until we brought him to a vet at the end, and found him a good permanent home.

Read the write-ups by Dan Wang , Craig Mod , Jason Kottke , and Liz Danzico , who were also on this walk, and go into more depth than I do here.

I highly recommend this activity and format.

You can start one yourself. It goes like this:

style="background-color: yellow;"> UPDATE: Kevin Kelly and Craig Mod released their "Walk and Talk: Everything We Know" PDF which is much more thorough and helpful than my brief overview, below. Download it here .

Choose where to walk — somewhere with lodging for 8 people every 15 km — where someone else can drive everyone's bags from place to place.

Someone (local person or business) walks it all in advance to make sure it's actually good. This person is the navigator.

Make a shared document of details of where to meet and what to bring, a group chat for questions, and a shared place to upload photos afterwards.

Invite a diverse group of conversationalists — ideally eight. Walkers send money to the local navigator to pre-pay for the lodging and meals.

Meet at the initial hotel for dinner and introductions.

Walk together for the next 6-7 days — ideally without phones — about 3-5 hours of walking per day , led by the navigator, with long breaks every two hours. Everyone naturally goes in and out of little 2-3 person conversations while walking.

Every night over a private dinner, the entire group has a single conversation around one subject , which the group chose the night before. Everyone stays involved in this one conversation, exploring one topic to exhaustion.

During this Thailand walk, our nightly conversation topics were:

How do you stay motivated?

What do you escape or resist?

What does home mean to you?

Shocking solutions to public problems.

Tell us about a failure.

Frameworks to make big decisions.

What is your health regime?

How do you use lists?

What do you believe that your heroes do not?

Some people spout their thoughts as soon as they come to mind. Other people need to be persuaded to share. It helps to moderate the conversation to keep the contributions balanced.

More than half of the conversations were during the day, one-on-one, while walking or resting. It's wonderful that you can come back to something someone said a day or two before, and share more thoughts or questions that came to you overnight.

It's one of the best things I've ever done.

Very healthy for your brain, body, and friendships.

I highly recommend it for anyone.

I plan to host some in the future. If you know a good place to do a "walk and talk" , (see criteria #1 above), please leave a suggestion in the comments here.

This is the wild dog that adopted us. I love him and miss him. Photos by Craig Mod .

Invite a diverse group of conversationalists — ideally eight.

Derek Sivers

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How the U.S. Civil War Made Christmas a National Holiday

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

We take for granted that the Christmas Season entails children are home from school, festive meals are being prepared, airports are crowded as people rush home to their families and parties are in full swing, all in anticipation of the jolly old elf Santa Claus's arrival. Not many people realize though that all of those traditions have their origins in the Civil War.

The religious nature of the holiday season upon us aside, this time of year has been a time of celebration and gift giving for centuries. The Twelve Days of Christmas and many other traditional songs, as well as Dickens's Christmas Carol, show that this is a celebration time that goes way back in the European culture. This week we are going to trace how the Civil War led to the making of Christmas as a secular, national holiday.

Unsurprisingly, the story is at base a political one. On Christmas Day 1861, President Lincoln chose to host a party at the White House. It was a crucial political moment because Mr Lincoln had a brewing international crisis that he had to stop before it got out of hand.

On Christmas Day 1862, the country was in a national panic. Setbacks in the war had made it anything but a happy season. On this day, Mr and Mrs Lincoln did something that seems so much a part of the responsibility of the POTUS on this holiday that its astounding that it hasn't always been traditional. And on Christmas in 1863, the Lincoln's made yet another gesture of good will to the soldiers in the field.

In 1861 President Lincoln sought to limit an international crisis by throwing a Christmas Party at the White House. The Trent Affair had led to the capture of the appointed Confederate representatives to Britain and France, John Slidell and James Murray Mason. War clouds had started to collect as the British Prime Minister insisted that the US had no right to capture these men on open seas. The capture occurred on November 8 and had become an international scandal after November 18. By Christmastime, there were rumors of British preparations for war and also significant diplomatic efforts were in progress. There were rumors of an invasion from Canada . So, there was a lot for Lincoln to "soft shoe" that day.

In 1862, the Lincoln Family began a tradition to counter the public effects of The Battle of Fredericksburg, which had been a military disaster that spawned a political and public relations catastrophe. "What will the country say?" Lincoln asked. But the POTUS was a political mastermind, and he turned crisis into opportunity, The Lincolns pointedly went the various hospitals around Washington and visited and spoke with the wounded. No president had ever done this before. It showed that Lincoln the commander in chief was a sensitive leader who felt the people's pain.

The hospital visits were so popular, and so necessary, that Lincoln continued them. He brought his son Tad with him on many such days. Tad was deeply moved by the soldiers. So on Xmas 1863, wounded soldiers received gifts of books and clothing from the White House, with a covering note that said, "From Tad Lincoln".

And in 1864, General Sherman telegraphed Lincoln on December 22, 1864 announcing the capture of Savannah. By 1865, as the image above shows, Christmas was a celebration of victory in the war.

The soldiers on the battlefield were far away from home, many had never been outside their county in their lives let alone their state. Union soldiers used salt pork and hardtack to decorate Christmas trees. Others were treated to special meals; a captain from Massachusetts treated his soldiers to foods such as turkey, oysters, pies, and apples; Singing carols was popular, ones that remain popular today, but Christmas cards would not become popular until the 1870s.

When we fly or drive home to Grandmothers House for Christmas, the origin of that tradition is the Civil War Fathers on both sides of the war were often given furloughs to return home for the holiday.

Christmas originates with a significant religious meaning and yet it has become secular in its celebration. Almost no one knows that this trend began in the Civil War. And even more surprising to many, without Thomas Nast, Christmas as we know it probably wouldn't exist. But Nast wasn't interested so much in Christmas. He was interested in a much bigger issue.

Nast was a cartoonist for Harper's Weekly during the Civil War. If Nast wasn't so interested in Christmas, why the recurrent theme? The 2 Nast cartoons depict Christmas experiences during the war. Identify the subjects of each and what was groundbreaking about them.

The fact is that Nast was a first class political cartoonist who was a Union sympathizing propagandist using Christmas to draw on the emotions of the season to bring the country together.

In the top cartoon, "Christmas Eve" (1862), a wreath frames a scene of a soldier's praying wife and sleeping children at home; a second wreath frames the soldier seated by a campfire, gazing longingly at small pictures of his loved ones.

Another illustration features Santa in his sleigh, then going down a chimney, in the top left of the cartoon. Somber scenes below remind of a grimmer reality—an army marching through snow and a row of frozen graves that refers to the Union's recent failure to take Fredericksburg. But there is hope: Santa is coming!

the January 3, 1863 issue of Harper's Weekly, Nast has an early caricature of Santa dressed in an American flag,

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TEDNext 2025 — in photos

TED Staff · TED Blog

TEDNext 2025 in Atlanta, now in its second year, celebrated those asking big questions about life, work and the world. Across three days of TED Talks, discovery sessions, meet-ups and more, attendees from 31 countries and every walk of life explored what's next, how to lead and what really matters. Below, enjoy a photo roundup from TEDNext 2025.

TEDNext 25 Photo Team: Leandro Badalotti, Ryan Lash, Erin Lubin, Callie Shields, Lynsey Weatherspoon and Elizabeth Zeeuw

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Prisoner of War Exchanges in the U.S. Civil War: The Lieber Code - Part 1

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Early in the U. S. Civil War a prison exchange system was developed by agreement between the two sides. It called for equal exchanges of all soldiers captured based on rank. Once exchanged, these soldiers could return to their units. The balance remaining after equal exchanges were to be paroled, and not to take up arms again until they were formally exchanged.

On July 22, 1862, Union Maj Gen John A Dix and Confederate Major General Daniel Harvey Hill concluded an agreement for the general exchange of prisoners between the Union and Confederate armies. A scale of equivalents was developed wherein an officer might be exchanged for a certain number of enlisted men, or might entail a parole in which no military capacity was allowed until officially exchanged. Officers were exchanged for more soldiers than others. The operation of the system was:

The Exchange System worked well in 1862 but there were irregularities on both sides, in which paroled men nevertheless rejoined their units. Edwin Stanton wanted to suspend the exchanges because he felt that southern soldiers weren't following the rules of the parole. Secretary Stanton saw a potential for Union soldiers to abuse the parole system. The Confederates had begun paroling a number of Western prisoners unilaterally, including some two thousand taken at the April 1862 battle of Shiloh. The violations continued with the parolees from Vicksburg and Port Hudson.

In September of 1862, President Lincoln called for the enlistment of black soldiers into the Union Armies as part of the preliminary draft of the Emancipation Proclamation. In December 1862, President Davis responded by issuing a proclamation that neither captured black soldiers nor their white officers would be subject to exchange. That the black soldiers were fugitive slaves and subject to capital punishment.

President Davis made an official proclamation that black POWs were fugitive slaves. In May 1863, the Confederate Congress passed a joint resolution that formalized Davis' proclamation that black soldiers taken prisoner would not be exchanged: "That all commissioned officers in the command of said Benjamin F. Butler be declared not entitled to be considered as soldiers engaged in honorable warfare but as robbers and criminals deserving death, and that they and each of them be whenever captured reserved for execution." Find the proclamation here: <http://www.freedmen.umd.edu/pow.htm>

Lincoln's response was to assure that The Lieber Code, General Order 100, issued in April 1863, responded to this crisis. The Lieber Code was not written as a direct reaction to the collapse of the Dix-Hill Cartel or Jefferson Davis's refusal to recognize Black Union soldiers as lawful combatants. But the final form, timing, and political pur-

pose of the code were very heavily shaped by those crises. In effect, the breakdown of prisoner exchange and Confederate policy toward Black soldiers turned the Lieber Code from a general effort to codify the laws of war into a strategic and moral response to the Confederacy's stance.

Henry Halleck had long wanted an American codification of the laws of war. Francis Lieber had been thinking about such a code for years, drawing on European theory. The War Department's Law of War Committee met in late 1862—months before Davis's December 1862 proclamation threatening to treat captured Black Union soldiers as slaves and their white officers as criminals.

While not the original motivation, the timing and urgency of the Lieber Code reflect the breakdown of the Dix-Hill Cartel (mid-late 1862) and Davis's policy. The Union needed a principled basis to suspend the Cartel. One of its articles stipulated that the United States government expected all prisoners to be treated equally, regardless of color. By late 1862 it was clear that the Confederacy would not exchange or treat Black Union soldiers as POWs. The cartel was therefore unworkable. The Lincoln administration needed a legal and moral justification for halting exchanges without appearing to commit retaliation for its own sake.

The Lieber Code provided it—explicitly authorizing retaliation when the enemy violates the laws of war; the equal treatment of all lawful combatants regardless of race; the duty of the U. S. government to protect all its soldiers. This was crucial. It offered a codified, internationally resonant legal framework for the Union's stance. The full document can be found here: https://avalon.law.yale.edu/19th_century/lieber.asp#sec3

Franz Lieber was a German-American legal scholar. He had fought with the Prussian Army and been wounded at Waterloo. He later moved and taught for 20 years in South Carolina, where he was repulsed by slavery. In 1861 he became professor of law at Columbia University in NYC. Two of his sons fought for the Union, a third fought for the Confederacy and was killed in action. Halleck, a lawyer with an interest in International Law, consulted Lieber regarding ethical dilemmas early on and invited him, along with Stanton, to undertake this project.

The Lieber Code expressly forbade giving "no quarter" to the enemy (i.e. killing prisoners of war), except in such cases when the survival of the unit that held these prisoners was threatened. It forbade the use of poisons, stating that use of such puts any force who uses them entirely outside the pale of the civilized nations and peoples; it forbade the use of torture to extract confessions or information; it described the rights and duties of prisoners of war and of capturing forces. Most of its ideas were incorporated into the Hague Convention of 1907, and are the fundamental rules of war to this day.

The Lieber Code is formulated as a series of x articles, really just statements of principle. Section III is

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A Brief History of Scotland's Dry Towns

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Prohibition is very often associated with the criminal activities of the infamous Al Capone, his nemesis Eliot Ness, and numerous illegal speakeasies from the USA between 1920 and 1933 made memorable from numerous gangster films over the decades. Prohibition, after a fashion at least, was not just confined to North America. It did in fact reach Britain and established itself in a quieter way in some remote towns in Scotland. Kirkintilloch was one of those towns and famously stands out among many for having prohibition laws that continued late into the twentieth century.

Kirkintilloch can be found eight miles from central Glasgow. The town started life as a Roman fort and led a quiet and largely quiet life until the industrial revolution brought the benefit of the textile industry to its inhabitants. Further expansion followed with the building of Forth and Fyfe canal in 1773 and later in 1836 with the railways. The town became an important transport center for iron, coal, and other industrial needs.

Kirkintilloch would have remained just another industrial town, but the town earned its notoriety for becoming what was known as a "dry town" which forbid the sale of alcohol on public premises from 1923 until 1967. Kirkintilloch was not alone and was one of many towns in Scotland that embraced prohibition. The ban on the sale of alcohol had long been demanded by both the Liberal Party and the Temperance movement, both of which had a strong influence in Scottish local town politics in the early part of the 20th century. It was a combination of the Temperance movement and the outbreak of the First World War that created "dry towns" which lasted long into the twentieth century and the infamous prohibition period of the United States.

The origin of Scotland's former dry towns began with the Temperance movement, a movement that led a moral crusade against alcohol consumption in the USA in the early 1800s. Its ideas were soon in Britain. The movement did not find it difficult to find supporters all over Britain but found strong and more lasting support in Scotland in the mid 1800s. The movement focused on the morally degrading effect that alcohol consumption had on society. One writer on the subject, Jack S Blocker, in his book *Alcohol and Temperance in Modern History* pays particular attention to the situation in Scotland. The book mentions a parliamentary report that contained alarming statistics concerning drink-related arrests between 1831 and 1851 in Scotland. It painted Glasgow in a poor light. The report concluded that the situation was not helped by the ratio of drinking establishments per inhabitant. In Glasgow there was one licensed premises for every one-hundred and fifty inhabitants. As far as Temperance Movement was concerned this was all the proof needed to convince potential followers for assertive action.

The report boldly claimed that "Glasgow was three times more drunken than Edinburgh and five times more drunk than London." He also noted that Scots "like the Irish and unlike the English and Welsh, ordinary people drank a great deal of whisky." We cannot confirm the accuracy of the data, which no doubt had its flaws, nor do the unhelpful and outdated stereotypes help to substantiate these claims. However, whether true, false, or exaggerated the report caused enough alarm for the Temperance movement to fuel their crusade and so it grew and gathered momentum.

Kirkintilloch was not the only dry town in Scotland; others soon joined the moral cause after the passing of the later 1913 Temperance Act. At first the movement's demands were limited to just banning the sale of "strong and ardent spirits" but soon those demands encapsulated the banning of all alcoholic drinks. Variants of the movement spread to other towns in Scotland such as Paisly, Kilsyth, Wick, Lerwick, Greenock, Ayrshire, and Lanarkshire. In 1844 in Falkirk, the Scots Temperance League established itself in the community and promoted "the long pledge" of total abstinence from its members.

The first challenge the Temperance representatives had to overcome was encouraging the drinking population to surrender one of their few leisurely pastimes, especially those who grafted in the long hours and harsh working conditions of the time. It was no easy task, but the members found innovative ways. Various movements offered extremely attractive terms in return to leading a teetotal life and being part of the movement.

In return for a serious commitment to a clear oath or pledge, the member would receive support in various forms from this new community. In some variants of the movement, certain benefits were offered such as the entitlement to an early form of social welfare type insurance to draw on in times of need, representing an early example of a Co-operative or a micro social security system. This was certainly true of the Sons of the Temperance Society which formed in the 1850s. The oath was noticeably clear, and each faction had its own wording, but all had one clear and unified meaning. The Hope of Coatbridge Section of the Cadets of Temperance (1878-1925), for example, had their members recite the following vows:

In the towns where the Temperance ideas took hold the old-fashioned public house was replaced by other commercial ventures and for a time flourished. Alternative establishments such as Temperance hotels, coffee houses and tea rooms replaced these licensed premises. The social scene was changing in some areas. Over twenty such establishments replaced the public house in Glasgow in 1840 and the movement was gaining political approval.

Meanwhile these societies continued to lobby and win the approval of political influencers. One peer commented: "Without these societies we should be involved in such an ocean of intoxication, violence and sin as would make this country quite uninhabitable." The lobbying proved to be fruitful and the best example of the

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Here's how to live: Follow the great book.

Derek Sivers

You know what your great book is.

Whether the Bible, Tanakh, Upanishads, Quran, Think and Grow Rich, Seven Habits of Highly Effective People, or another, follow it diligently.

Your book is wiser than you.

It's describing natural law — the way our world works.

It's not just someone's opinion.

It has the definitive answers to the choices you're confronted with each day.

Don't think you know better.

People say they want to make their own decisions.

But imagine that you have a life-or-death medical situation, so you rush to the doctor, and the doctor says, "There are hundreds of different approaches we could take. You decide. It's up to you."

You would say, "No! You're the doctor. You're the expert. You know best. You decide. Tell me what to do."

Your book is the expert on how to live.

It's helped millions of people.

Defer to its wisdom.

Your book was meant for people exactly like you.

You're not an exception to humanity.

Its rules apply to you.

It guides you on a good life.

If your book is ancient, you may think it's not enough since it doesn't mention modern life.

But nothing is truly new.

Morals seem like they've changed in recent history.

But really, morals haven't changed in longer history.

If you update the language and some references, books written thousands of years ago sound like they could have been written today.

The human condition remains the same.

Your book has all the wisdom you need.

Read metaphorically, and apply it to your modern life.

You don't lack direction.

You have too many directions.

An open mind, like an open mouth, needs to eventually close on something.

Stop swerving and chasing new leaders.

Stay on a single steady path.

Following your book is how to live.

First, make a "born again" split.

Let go of your old identity.

Let your new self be incongruent with your old self.

Let your friends and family know that you've changed.

Bring your book with you everywhere as a constant reminder and reference.

Refer to its rules in every situation, every day.

Memorize its crucial sentences.

Keep them at the forefront of your mind.

Following rules is smart.

It's efficient.

You don't need to stop and re-think every situation.

"Follow your passion" is terrible advice.

Fleeting interests are a bad compass.

Passions pass so quickly that to follow them would have you dashing around like a dog chasing bubbles.

Don't follow your heart.

Your heart has been hacked.

Your intuition is usually wrong because it's just emotion, subliminally influenced by amoral inputs.

Emotions are a wild animal.

You need rules to tame them.

Rules give you freedom from your desires.

When you rise above your instincts, you still feel them but no longer do what they say.

Following your emotions is not freedom.

Being free from following emotions is freedom.

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How to Think Like a World-Class Marketer | Rory Sutherland

Vicky · Farnam Street ([fs.blog](#))

Ogilvy Vice Chairman Rory Sutherland reveals the formula for persuasion, why people make decisions and how you can use psychology to your advantage.

AI and Decision Making

Why Is Dyson So Effective at Marketing?

Warren Buffett's Approach to Choosing Management

How to Write Good Copy

Rory is the world's leading advertising strategist. He spent almost four decades at Ogilvy studying why people behave the way they do and how to change that behavior.

He explains why contrast drives choices and efficiency often destroys value, and how trust, friction, and design shape real-world behavior.

Available Now: [Apple Podcasts](#) | [Spotify](#) | [YouTube](#) | [X](#) | [Transcript](#)

+Rory was previously on the show; check out episode 19 .

Trust is the only shortcut.

Visible costs often hide invisible benefits.

Efficiency is the enemy of magic.

Rules protect the rule-follower.

Price is a signal.

Character is a proxy for quality.

If you survive long enough, you get lucky.

Most problems are human, not technical.

Consumption is about identity, not utility.

Creativity starts where logic stops.

Innovation is behavior change.

Context creates value.

Status games can't be turned off, only redirected.

Differentiation is generosity.

The map rewards the mapmaker.

Customer contact is an honor, not a cost.

The best technology rarely wins.

Overpaying can be rational. You only get some chances once.

Complaints are R&D, not a cost.

Weirdness creates monopolies.

Rationality isn't enough. To really win, you have to go beyond logic. If you only do what makes sense, you're competing with everyone else who has the same data. The magic happens when you do the things that look wrong on a spreadsheet.

Efficiency is the enemy of magic. Any idiot can cut visible costs by firing the doorman. But the invisible costs are where the magic happens. When you optimize for efficiency, you often kill the very thing that customers value.

Character is a proxy for quality. When people can't judge a product's quality, they judge the seller's character. If they trust you, they trust what you're selling. Character is the ultimate warranty.

The map is not the territory. Spreadsheets are the map; customer problems are the territory. If you run your business by the numbers, you are hallucinating. You have to touch the customers to know where you really are.

Complaints are R&D, not a cost. A call from a customer is an honor, not an interruption. The call center isn't a cost to be minimized; it's your best source of intelligence. If you automate away the human connection, you remove your ability to learn.

Price is a feature, not just a number. We don't just pay for utility, we pay for how the transaction makes us feel. A higher price can actually improve the experience by signaling value and generosity. Sometimes the best way to improve a product is to charge more for it.

Weirdness creates monopolies. If you follow the rules, you compete with everyone else. If you do something that seems irrational but works, you stand alone. The best advantage is being the only one crazy enough to do what you do.

We don't know what we want until we see what we don't. AI fails when it tries to give us the "perfect" answer immediately. Humans need comparison to understand value. You have to show people the wrong option so they can recognize the right one.

Invention needs more marketing, not less. The best product doesn't win; the most familiar one does. New ideas trigger our fear of the unknown. If you're truly innovating, you need to work twice as hard to make people feel safe enough to try it.

Inefficiency is a filter for character. A little friction is good for the soul. How someone handles a slight delay or a mistake tells you everything about how they'll handle a crisis.

Don't measure a home run with a stopwatch. Creative work

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Database triggers to clean text inputs

Derek Sivers

Even smart people can accidentally put bad data into a database.

We copy text from a web page, then paste it into a form, not realizing it also copied a space, tab, or newline character. Then your system thinks someone's name is not "Jim" but "Jim\n".

You could use JavaScript to sanitize all form inputs, but what about when you import a CSV file, or get data from an API?

No, the best place for your data-cleaning functions is in the database itself. So no matter what code is inserting or updating, a database trigger will sanitize it before saving.

Here's a PostgreSQL example. Let's make two tables, people and emails, so you can see how one function can be used by many triggers.

create table emails (id serial primary key, person_id integer not null references people(id), email text); download code

Let's make two simple functions:

Remove all whitespace, then lowercase.

Remove unwanted whitespace characters like tab and newline. Replace them all with a single space. Then trim spaces from the front and end.

– replace all whitespace with single space, then trim start and end create function no_extra_space(text) returns text as \$\$ select btrim(regexp_replace(\$1, '\s+', ' ', 'g')); \$\$ language sql; download code

The function that removes all whitespace then lowercases, is good for email addresses and codes like checksums.

The function that removes extra whitespace then trims, is good for many things like names, addresses, email subjects, and anywhere that needs to retain inner spaces. So "New \t Zealand \n" will be "New Zealand".

Now make trigger functions that use your smaller re-usable cleaning functions. I find it best to make one trigger per table, sanitizing all fields on any insert or update.

```
class="code"> create function clean_people() returns trigger as $$ begin new.name = no_extra_space(new.name); new.code = lower_no_space(new.code); return new; end; $$ language plpgsql; create trigger clean_people before insert or update on people for each row execute procedure clean_people();
```

```
create function clean_emails() returns trigger as $$ begin new.email = lower_no_space(new.email); return new; end; $$ language plpgsql; create trigger clean_emails before in-
```

}

sert or update on emails for each row execute procedure clean_emails(); download code

The language is a little verbose, but oh well. The ugliness of the boilerplate code is made up for by the beautiful simplicity of having all of this handled in the database. It's so nice to not have to sanitize form fields! Just toss the unwashed inputs at the database.

Here, let's give it some dirty data, and watch it come out clean.

```
class="code"> insert into people (name, code) values (e' \t \r \n Dr. \n \r JM \t Lim \r \n', 'XX o Z ') returning *; - id | name | code - - - - - 1 | Dr. JM Lim | xxoz
```

```
insert into emails (person_id, email) values (1, e' \r \n \t DR. L @ JM Lim . com \n') returning *; - id | person_id | email - - - - - 1 | 1 | dr.l@jmlim.com download code
```

This approach has made my code much simpler, and data much cleaner.

Download the full code example at </code/clean1.sql>.

Also look at using triggers to ensure data integrity.

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The Forgotten Bombers That Led the Way: America's Vivid Assembly Ships of World War II

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

During the height of the air war over Europe, large groups of American heavy bombers climbed out of East Anglia almost every morning. For many people living in the region, the sound and sight of those aircraft became a familiar part of the conflict. The United States Army Air Forces depended heavily on the B-17 Flying Fortress and the B-24 Liberator for its daylight strategy, and their departures became routine. What rarely receives the same attention is the role of a handful of older bombers that helped bring order to these departures. These were the assembly ships, painted in bright and sometimes unusual colors so crews could spot them quickly against the English sky.

The Challenge of Bringing Order to the Skies

From 1943 onward, the Eighth Air Force expanded its operations across East Anglia. Airfields were spread across Norfolk, Suffolk, and Cambridgeshire, and each one sent aircraft into the same busy morning sky. Every bomber had to find its place in a larger group, climb steadily, and keep to the timetable. Weather often interfered, and crews still adjusting to British conditions sometimes struggled to identify other aircraft in the haze.

The result was predictable. Aircraft sometimes climbed into the same airspace. Near misses were reported frequently. Several bombing missions suffered delays because the formations failed to gather quickly enough. Although ground control could guide departures, it could not solve the issue of identifying other aircraft in the air. Another solution was needed, one that crews could see without relying on radio contact or clear skies.

A Practical Innovation in a Growing Air War

The answer was the assembly ship. These were older bombers nearing the end of their combat life. Some had battle damage that made long missions impossible, while others had simply become worn. Instead of being scrapped immediately, many were converted into highly visible airborne rally points. Each bomb group had one, sometimes two, depending on operational needs.

The idea was straightforward. The assembly ship took off first and climbed into a holding pattern above its home base. Newer aircraft took off next and circled until they spotted the brightly painted machine overhead. Once enough aircraft had gathered, the assembly ship guided the formation into the correct climbing pattern and direction of travel. After completing the task, it returned to base. It did not cross the North Sea or accompany the mission toward its target.

Color Schemes Designed to Be Impossible to Miss

The thing that makes assembly ships so memorable today is their appearance. Because they never flew into enemy territory, camouflage was unnecessary. Visibility

became the priority. Groups across the Eighth Air Force began to develop their own designs, often with considerable imagination.

One aircraft might be painted bright yellow with red chevrons. Another might have wide black spots across a silver fuselage. Some had candy-striped tails. Others carried oversized geometric shapes or checkerboard patterns. A few used contrasting panels of green and white. The design language varied, but every scheme aimed at the same goal. Crews had to recognize the ship instantly, even in bad weather.

These color schemes created some of the most distinctive aircraft of the Second World War. They were not meant to impress the enemy or hide from it. They were meant for the airmen who needed to find their group quickly at dawn.

Conversions and Modifications

The aircraft chosen for this role were usually B-17s or B-24s. Each type required a fair amount of modification. Guns were removed, which reduced weight and made the aircraft easier to climb. Armor plate was often taken out for the same reason. Much of the interior was removed, along with equipment that was no longer needed. Lightening the aircraft made it easier for the assembly ship to get up early and remain overhead long enough for the rest of the group to form up.

Some groups gave their assembly ships names that embraced their unusual appearance. The 458th Bomb Group operated a B-24 known as "Spotted Cow". Another group had "The Green Dragon", painted in a vivid green finish with yellow markings. There were others, including "The Jolly Roger" and "Fightin' Sam". The names added a touch of character, but the paintwork did most of the talking.

Routine Work That Never Reached the Headlines

Assembly ships rarely appear in wartime newsreels or photographs. Their work was uneventful by design. They did not fly through flak or fighter attack. They were not part of the dramatic footage that accompanied raids on Berlin or the Ruhr. Yet their flights were essential. A large formation needed clarity and coordination. Without it, missions risked breakdown long before reaching the target.

Veterans often described the sense of relief that came with spotting the brightly colored aircraft circling above the base. In the low morning light, with engines warming and visibility uncertain, that visual cue gave crews a clear point of reference. They knew exactly where to go and how to start the long climb eastward.

Safety, Training, and an Air War Under Pressure

The arrival of assembly ships also made the morning departure routine noticeably safer. With so many

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The stories that stay: What remains when memory fades

TED Staff · TED Blog

By Brigid Jacoby, with Amanda Lynch

November is National Alzheimer's Awareness Month, a time to pause, reflect and continue the conversation on a disease that touches millions of lives around the world. Alzheimer's isn't just a medical challenge — it's an emotional one that reshapes families, identities and the way we connect with one another.

Every TED Talk begins with a story. Every story begins with a memory. That is the idea at the heart of the TED Memory Project, created in partnership with Eli Lilly and Company. It's a multi-platform, multi-month movement that explores how memory drives innovation and connection while advancing understanding and empathy around Alzheimer's.

In his TED Talk, "Where does your sense of self come from? A scientific look," Anil Ananthaswamy shares: "Take, for instance, the question 'Who am I?' The most likely answer you will get or give to such a question will be in the form of a story. We tell others, and indeed ourselves, stories about who we are. We take our stories to be sacrosanct. We are our stories. But a condition that most of us, sadly, will be familiar with, Alzheimer's disease, tells us something quite different. Alzheimer's begins by affecting short-term memory. Think about what that does to someone's story. In order for our stories to form, to grow, something that just happens to us has to first enter short-term memory and then get incorporated into what is called long-term episodic memory. It has to become an episode in our narrative."

This blog is one way of continuing that work, giving space for voices like Brigid Jacoby's to reflect on how Alzheimer's can alter identity and the stories that shape us. It is a space for reflection, where ideas meet lived experience, and where the threads of resilience, grief, curiosity and hope come into focus.

When Brigid watched Anil's TED Talk, one idea struck her: our sense of self is built on the stories we tell about our past, our families and the choices we have made. Alzheimer's complicates this deeply because it disrupts short-term memory, the very building blocks of those stories. Without being able to record and recall, the narrative of who we are becomes harder to sustain. "That idea resonated with me because I have seen firsthand how Alzheimer's can change a person's sense of self, not by erasing them, but by reshaping how their identity is expressed," Brigid said.

Brigid shares her reflections after the recent passing of her mother, Anne, who lived with early-onset Alzheimer's. Anne passed on October 30th, 2025, early in the morning, surrounded by her three children. She began experiencing symptoms in her late forties, with her first memory complaints documented at 51. At first, it was small things like misplacing her keys, forgetting dates or struggling with her computer. But soon, the disease began interfering with her

work. After more than 20 years in her industry, she lost her job, and even retail shifts became difficult when she couldn't navigate the digital sales system. Brigid's younger sibling even took a job at the same shop just to help keep an eye on her.

Anne was a storyteller. As an Irish American, she carried forward the histories of her grandparents immigrating from Ireland, weaving them into a family tapestry she often shared with her children. Her sense of self was tied to these stories and to the act of passing them down.

"One day, sitting outside with my mom, I asked her to retell a story about my great-grandmother," Brigid recalls. "But this time, I watched panic rise in her eyes as she struggled to understand what I was referencing. The words did not come. Instead, tears did. It was not just memory loss, it was a fracture in identity, the vanishing of a thread she had long held onto as proof of who she was and where she came from."

Over time, Brigid and her siblings learned to meet Anne in a different place, one not rooted in lost stories but in new ways of being together. They leaned into humor, curiosity and wonder. They asked silly questions, marveled with her at the shape of plants and clouds, or let her imagination spin freely without the pressure of accuracy. In those moments, Anne still expressed herself. Not through the precise retelling of family history, but through joy, silliness and awe.

Anil's TED Talk reminded Brigid that even as memory fades, the self is not gone — it is simply altered. As Ananthaswamy explains, "I also believe that altered selves should not be seen as the outcome of deficits, or as the outcome of a lack of attributes considered normal. They are different ways of being, and it is the willingness of some of us to confront the self's constructed nature that is helping make sense of the self for all of us."

That is why Alzheimer's awareness matters to her. She wants people to understand that while the disease changes a person, it does not erase them, a lesson she carries forward after her mother's recent passing. "This awareness gives us tools to show up differently," Brigid said. "To support loved ones as they move into a new version of themselves, rather than turning away in fear or discomfort. My hope is that people can approach those living with Alzheimer's with patience, curiosity and care, seeking to understand what they are experiencing instead of mourning only what has been lost. By doing so, we can honor who they are becoming, not just who they were."

Because behind every statistic is a person like Anne, whose story Brigid now carries forward. And behind every talk is someone like Brigid, reminding us why these conversations must continue.

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Marco Polo: The Venetian who Brought the East to Europe

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Marco Polo stands as one of the most iconic figures of medieval exploration, a man whose name became synonymous with far-flung lands, daring journeys, and the opening of new worlds to the imagination of Europe. Born in 1254 CE into a Venetian merchant family, Marco Polo grew up in a city that was then a thriving hub of Mediterranean commerce. His father, Niccolò Polo, and his uncle, Maffeo, were seasoned merchants with experience trading in Constantinople and along routes leading deep into Asia. Their ventures laid the groundwork for Marco's own journeys, ensuring he was raised with an understanding of trade, diplomacy, and the lure of distant markets. Marco's mother died when he was young, leaving his extended family to raise him. By the time he reached his late teens, the Polo family's mercantile ambitions had drawn him into one of the greatest adventures of the Middle Ages.

In 1271, Marco Polo, at just seventeen, set out with his father and uncle on a journey that would take them across Asia to the Mongol court of Kublai Khan, the powerful grandson of Genghis Khan. Their route followed the Silk Road, a web of trade paths that stretched across deserts, mountains, and great cities, linking Europe with Asia. The journey was arduous, spanning thousands of miles through regions plagued by political instability, banditry, and natural hardships.

The Polos travelled through the Middle East, passing through Acre and crossing Persia, where Marco was exposed to Zoroastrianism and Islamic culture. From there, they trekked across Afghanistan's rugged terrain, scaled the heights of the Pamir Mountains, and crossed the vast steppes of Central Asia before reaching China. Marco, experiencing these lands for the first time, recorded their customs, geography, and products with a keen eye for detail. His descriptions, later written down, became the first systematic attempt to convey knowledge of Asia to Europeans.

When the Polos arrived at Kublai Khan's court around 1275 CE, they entered one of the most powerful empires the world had ever known. The Mongol Empire stretched across Eurasia, and Kublai ruled as the founder of the Yuan dynasty in China. Marco quickly impressed the khan with his intelligence, linguistic aptitude, and curiosity. Unlike most Europeans who reached Asia, Marco did not remain on the fringes of court life; instead, he became a trusted envoy and administrator.

Over the next seventeen years, Marco Polo travelled extensively across China and beyond, often on missions for Kublai Khan. He reported seeing the dazzling city of Hangzhou, which he called the most splendid city he had ever encountered, with its bustling markets, canals, and vibrant cultural life. He journeyed to Yunnan in the southwest, observed the production of salt, described the use of coal as a source of heat, and marveled at China's system of

paper currency, which seemed like a miracle to Europeans accustomed only to gold and silver.

Marco's accounts also extended beyond China. He wrote of voyages to Southeast Asia, describing the islands of Sumatra and Java, and even hinted at distant Japan, known to him as Cipangu, which was said to hold great riches. His descriptions were sometimes a blend of direct observation and second-hand reports, but together they painted a remarkable picture of lands far beyond Europe's horizon.

What distinguished Marco Polo was not only his access to Kublai Khan's empire but his ability to observe and record with precision. He provided detailed descriptions of China's postal system, in which relays of riders could carry messages across vast distances with astonishing speed. He noted the cultivation of rice, the production of silk, and the intricate social customs of the Chinese people.

Yet he also reported marvels that seemed fantastical to European readers. He spoke of rhinoceroses, which he mistook for the mythical unicorn, and of stones that burned like fire, a reference to coal. He described strange religious practices, palaces roofed with gold, and exotic animals that few in Europe had ever seen. His accounts mixed practical knowledge with elements of wonder, a blend that ensured his book would captivate audiences for centuries.

However, by 1291 CE, the Polos were ready to return to Venice. Their departure from Kublai Khan's court was delicate, as the khan valued their service. They gained permission to escort a Mongol princess to Persia, and after a long sea voyage through the South China Sea and the Indian Ocean, they eventually made their way back across Asia and arrived home in 1295 CE. Marco Polo had been gone for twenty-four years.

The Venetians who greeted him hardly recognized him. He returned wealthy, adorned in fine robes, and with tales so extraordinary that many thought them impossible. Yet his knowledge of distant lands, goods, and languages set him apart from any other traveler of his generation.

Not long after his return, Venice found itself at war with its rival Genoa. Marco Polo, serving as a naval commander, was captured during the Battle of Curzola in 1298 CE and imprisoned. It was during this imprisonment that his life took another remarkable turn. Sharing a cell with the romance writer Rustichello da Pisa, Marco dictated the story of his travels. Rustichello, with a flair for embellishment, shaped Marco's recollections into a narrative that combined detailed description with elements of wonder and adventure.

The resulting work, *Il Milione*, known in English as *The Travels of Marco Polo*, became one of the most influential travel books of the medieval world. More than just a record of trade routes, it offered a vivid picture of Asia's geography, politics, economy, and culture. While skeptics dismissed it as exaggerated fantasy, others treated it as a treasure trove of knowledge. Copies spread across

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CodeSOD: A Little Twisted

Remy Porter · The Daily WTF

Dana sends us a WTF that'll turn your head. She was shopping for new hard drives, and was doing it from her phone, a fairly reasonable tool to use for online shopping these days. She opened the website of one vendor, and it was rotated 90 degrees. Or half-pi radians, for those of us that are more used to sensible units.

This was irrespective of any rotation settings on her phone, the website insisted on showing itself in landscape mode. This created quite the unusual appearance when she held her phone in portrait orientation: the browser chrome surrounding the content was in portrait mode, but the page itself was in landscape.

Obviously, this is a terrible design choice. But Dana wanted to know more. So she started digging in. There was no sign of this behavior on a desktop, which sure, I'd hope not. Attempting to use wget to download the page caused a 403. Using curl downloaded a JavaScript challenge. Fine, they didn't want bots, but Dana wasn't a bot.

Poking around in the network tab of the desktop browser's debugging tools helped Dana learn a few things. First: the line endings in the files were all CRLF, implying that all development happened on Windows machines. Maybe that's not interesting, but in 2026, it feels unusual. Second, the page is setting a PHPSESSID cookie, so clearly the backend is written in PHP. But most important, Dana is able to piece together what she needs to successfully use curl to download the page, once pretending to be a desktop browser, and once pretending to be a mobile browser. With that, she ran a diff to see what changed.

The desktop version started with 42 blank lines. The mobile version started with 41. The rest of the pages were substantially the same, with two exceptions. First, the mobile page also added a stylesheet called stylesheet-responsive.css. I assume that name was chosen because irony is dead; nothing about this site is responsive. Second, there was a subtle difference in the body tags.

You see, both pages had a body tag like this:

But the mobile page, continued from there:

Yes, the mobile version has two body tags.

Dana writes:

Even though I don't have access to the real PHP source-code, I can imagine what it looks like.

Somewhere in that PHP source-code there is browser-detection (or rather browser-sniffing) and that toggles if it should serve a slightly different HTML code to the user. I do not want to work for that website, I do not want to look at that backend source-code. And I have to feel sorry and

respect for the browser developers, as they have to write software that can handle completely broken HTML.

While I hate the results, the fact that the HTML specification originally required clients to render even the most broken HTML is arguably a really good design choice. Expecting people to do the right thing never works out for you.

Let's not forget their "responsive" CSS, which is obviously worth looking at, even if it's obvious what it must be:

```
@media only screen and ( orientation :portrait)
{ #landscape_mode_only { height : 98vw ; -webkit- transform : rotate ( 90deg ); -moz- transform : rotate ( 90deg ); -o- transform : rotate ( 90deg ); -ms- transform : rotate ( 90deg ); transform : rotate ( 90deg ) } }
```

This forces everything in the body to rotate sideways.

Look, actually responsive design is hard. But "just force the page into landscape mode no matter what the user does" is definitely not the solution.

And Dana points out one last thing:

As a cherry on the top, observe how the comment that marks the end of the header is placed after the starts. Which is wrong already, but also stupid, because already marks the end of the head. And the head is not really the header.

[Advertisement] BuildMaster allows you to create a self-service release management platform that allows different teams to manage their applications. Explore how!

```
style="clear: left;">
```

With that, she ran a diff to see what changed.

Remy Porter

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The Making of a Swadeshi Economy in India's Freedom Struggle

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Mayer Amschel Rothschild, the founder of the Rothschild banking dynasty famously said “Give me control of a nation’s money and I care not who makes its laws”, suggesting that whoever controls the economy of a country has more power than the lawmakers. The Swadeshi Movement, while fundamentally political, was India’s realization of this truth and understanding the importance of economic control. Over the years, many historians and scholars have given their definition of the term “Swadeshi”, all revolving around self-sufficiency and local self-reliance.

According to Gandhi, the term Swadeshi is “that spirit within us which restricts us to the use and service of our immediate surroundings to the exclusion of the more remote.” He promoted the importance of indigenous skills, using them to live a simple and dignified life. For Sri Aurobindo, “It is an intellectual change, it is a spiritual change, it is a political change...Swadeshi is that which belongs to our own country. When applied to industry and commerce it means the preference for our own articles produced by Indian labour and the exclusion of articles produced by the labour of foreign people.” Lisa N. Trivedi opines that the “social collective of Bharat (the dominant indigenous term for India) was the template on which popular swadeshi repertoires were forged.”

The Swadeshi Movement went beyond mere boycott and eventually became a way of living. This idea has been stressed upon in Gandhian philosophy and also in influential works like that of Rabindranath Tagore’s 1904 essay ‘Swadeshi Samaj’. It emerged as a mass political movement from 1905 onwards and developed into a crucial instrument for economic policy making post 1947, after Indian independence. This movement is about the making of a local economy and revival of the industries that were disbanded by the British. Despite harsh measures such as arrests and lathi charges to suppress it, the movement had already succeeded in forging a sense of national identity among Indians.

Naoroji and the Indian National Congress had put forward their demands for industrial development, reduced taxes and promotion of Indian industries which were never given any importance. Between 1883 and 1892, Naoroji said that the total drain amounted to Rs. 24 crores which substantially increased to 51.5 crores by 1905. D. E. Wacha, the President of the Indian National Congress in 1901 also suggested that the drain was about thirty to forty crores. The figure varies as per the calculations of historians but drain of wealth from India was undeniably a major issue. In 1891, the Swadeshi agenda was adopted by the Indian National Congress. This became a national cause after the British Government amended the 1894 cotton duties in 1896 to benefit the textile manufacturers in Manchester by imposing a uniform 3.5% duty on manufactured Indian cloth.

Nitin Pai while tracing the early economic developments during the Swadeshi Movement highlights how “swadeshi...already became a social proxy against what many saw as political “mendicancy”. Bal Gangadhar Tilak in 1896 organized boycotts and publicly burned foreign cloth in Bombay. Mahadev Govind Ranade’s work through the Industrial Conference of Western India aimed to promote industrial development in Bombay in the late 1880s. This phase marked the establishment of early Swadeshi stores, indigenous banks and the rise of an entrepreneurial Indian class. Nitin Pai sheds light on the global movements during this emergent political phase such as the abolition of slavery in America, the American Civil War, Industrial Revolution, all culminating in changing the “pattern of the deployment of Indian capital.”

When Lord Curzon partitioned Bengal on October 16, 1905, his reasons revolved around Bengal being too large of a province. However, the main reason as supported by many historians was to curb Bengali nationalism, using the old tactic of “divide and rule” from the British playbook. In a 1903 memo, Curzon wrote: Bengal united is a power; Bengal divided will pull in different ways. East Bengal and Assam with approximately 31 million people became one unit while Bihar, Orissa and West Bengal formed the others. Little did Curzon expect that this move would act like a catalyst for the already brewing Swadeshi Movement.

Hundreds and thousands of people gathered on August 7, 1905 at Calcutta’ Town Hall chaired by moderate leader Surendranath Banerjee. Following this, students opted out of government schools, local banks and mills sprouted to promote the local economy. Some of the most prominent Swadeshi enterprises from Bengal include Acharya P. C. Ray’s Bengal Chemicals, Bange Lakshmi Cotton Mills, Calcutta Potteries and the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company (1906) by V. O. Chidambaram Pillai. In her article ‘Boycott of Lancashire Cloth: The real economic battle’, Diksha Tyagi observes how Import of foreign cloth declined by 1.5 crore rupees in 1907...Bombay’s textile mills, benefiting from increased demand for indigenous cloth, earned profits of over 2.7 crore rupees...” She further says that even Brahmins boycotted foreign goods and refused to perform pujas with those items.

When Gandhi arrived in 1915, he gave the movement a broader meaning by incorporating social, religious and cultural aspects. He promoted the khadi (cloth woven on handloom from fibers like cotton, silk, wool, etc.) as an alternative to the mill cloth and began spinning it in his Sabarmati Ashram. After World War I and brutal effects of the Great Depression in America, the British economy was slowly but surely crumbling. Khadi became a symbol of economic sufficiency and by 1925, the All India Spinners’ Association (AISA) was set up. They offered employment to women too who now became active economic contributors.

Another major blow to the British economy was the Dandi March of 1930, a part of the larger Civil Disobedience Movement. Following the principles of satyagraha (truth) and ahimsa (non-violence), this was a salt march

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Update on DoS Attacks against our Online Game

Dennis Felsing

In my previous post 8 months ago I described how our open source online game DDraceNetwork has been suffering under DoS attacks for about 8 years, basically since its inception. Recently the attacks have gotten much worse, forcing us to work on further approaches. Since many players made suggestions recently, I'm writing this blog post to summarize what we are attempting and to ask for help again.

These traffic graphs are from two of the servers we are running, note the logarithmic x-axis. Each spike represents an incoming DoS attack, as you can see some of them last for nearly a day.

Recently the attacks have been relatively weak in terms of incoming bandwidth, using spoofed IP addresses imitating our UDP-based connection process.

At first the CPU gets overloaded since the server suddenly has to try and handle hundreds of thousands of connection attempts per second. Since our game servers are mostly running on cheap VPSes and each game server runs single-threaded, it is quite easy to overload a system in this manner.

id="https-based-whitelist">HTTPS-based Whitelist

To prevent spoofing we collect all players' IP addresses and whitelist those. Since we also develop the game client, we can modify the client to connect to a server via HTTPs for this whitelisting. The iptables rules and ipset setup on the game servers for this whitelist look something like this:

```
ipset create official iphash ipset create whitelist-ip iphash
iptables -N serverinfo iptables -A serverinfo -m hashlimit
-hashlimit-above 40/s -hashlimit-mode dstport -hashlimit-
name si_dstport -j DROP iptables -N game iptables -A game
-m set -match-set official src -j ACCEPT iptables -A game -m
set -match-set whitelist-ip src -m u32 -u32 "38=0x67696533"
-j serverinfo iptables -A game -m set -match-set whitelist-
ip src -m u32 -u32 "38=0x66737464" -j serverinfo iptables
-A game -m set -match-set whitelist-ip src -j ACCEPT #
Still allow non-whitelisted players when there is no attack
iptables -A game -m limit -limit 10000 -j ACCEPT iptables
-A game -j DROP iptables -A INPUT -p udp -m udp -dport
8000:9000 -j game
```

To keep updating the whitelist we run a simple script:

```
#!/bin/sh rm -f whitelist whitelist.old touch whitelist.old
while true ; do curl -o whitelist $WHITELIST_URL LC_ALL
= C comm -23 whitelist whitelist.old | while read line ; do
ipset add whitelist-ip $line done mv whitelist whitelist.old
sleep 20 done
```

About 20 seconds after starting DDNet client the players are now being whitelisted and can join servers which are under

a spoofed DoS attack. We are employing this on the servers which are commonly attacked.

After a few days the ipset runs out of space unfortunately. Since we have 25k unique players daily, the default maximum element size of 65536 of ipset is quite tight. To work around this we'll have to increase the limit or remove older entries automatically.

In order to make this work reliably we had to disable IPv6 for the HTTPS access, since our game servers are IPv4 only at the moment and collecting IPv6 addresses doesn't help.

An unfortunate realization was that some ISPs don't provide fixed IPv4 addresses anymore, but instead tunnel their native IPv6 traffic through different IPv4 addresses, based on protocol and port. So we get one IP address in the HTTPS-based whitelist, but another when connecting to the gameserver via UDP. At least one Israeli ISP is doing this.

id="dedicated-servers">Dedicated Servers

For the second everything seemed to work fine when there was no attack, but during DoS attacks some player packets would get misflagged all the time.

Dennis Felsing

For some of the servers this whitelisting is not enough, since the hosters' DoS protection kicks in and starts aggressively blocking UDP traffic. This includes legitimate traffic and results in all players timing out on the game servers. I have tried talking to a few of the hosters about this, but it is by design since they don't support our game protocol, and wish to protect their own infrastructure as well as other customers. At least they are not kicking us out for now, which has happened in the past with a few hosters after multiple DoS attacks against us impacting their other customers.

So for a few locations we have upgraded to dedicated servers, where the hoster cares less about us exhausting in the incoming network connection and our CPUs for hours at a time. Unfortunately it is difficult to find hosters that provide more than 1 Gbit/s network bandwidth and still fall into our budget of 100 € / month.

The attackers of course notice that these servers can't be downed as easily, so they switch to different kinds of attacks, exhausting our measly 2 Gbit/s network.

id="small-hosting-companies">Small Hosting Companies

Some small hosting companies in Europe offered to help us by providing a free server with custom DoS protection. We accepted two such offers, but didn't have much success with either of them.

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A Review of The Paradox of Freedom: A History of Black Slaveholders in America

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

City of New Orleans, 5 March 1818. Order from the Mayor's office to the City Treasury to reimburse Rosette Montreuil, a free woman of color, for the work of her slave, Michel, "mulatto". Signed by mayor Augustin Macarty.

An Instructor of American History at Mississippi Delta Community College and an American Civil War Living Historian since 1995, Larry Allen McCluney received his bachelor's and master's degrees in history at Mississippi State University, and his research into original data for this book is extensive (he even utilized a History Is Now article). He cites and quotes many historians, as well as original sources, to bring to life a fact of American history: African Americans were slave owners too.

A mix of various "free peoples of color"—various mixed race and African Americans—owned people of their own race from colonial times up until after the Civil War. In some extreme cases slaves owned slaves. Some free African Americans even engaged in slave trading. This should not surprise us, as Africa has always been the center of slavery, where just as every other race in the world has been enslaved, and continues to enslave their own people. In fact, it was outside pressure from European nations that forced abolitionism on Africa.

African American slaveowners in America at times became some of the wealthiest planters and businessmen in the entire South. McCluney writes they became one with "the upper crust of the economic level in the pre-war South." They entered into and at times mingled, intermarried, and associated with the white southern aristocratic class. These wealthy included many African American women.

For example, he quotes Steven J. Niven, who wrote of "Marie-Thérèse Coincoin, who lived for eight decades in Natchitoches Parish, La. She would help to found a family dynasty of Free, Colored planters, the Metoyers, who by 1830 owned over 200 slaves—8 percent of all enslaved people in the parish." In Charleston City, South Carolina, 123 African American women owned slaves and were the "heads" of households, including Maria Weston, who by 1860 owned 14 slaves and owned property amounting to \$40,000; the average white earned around \$100. Marie Thérèse Metoyer of New Orleans owned around 11,000 acres of land, manufactured medicine, trapped animals, and grew tobacco.

"In 1860, there were at least six free Blacks who owned 65 or more slaves. The largest number, 152 slaves, was owned by sugar cane planters, the widow C. Richards and her son P. C. Richards. Another slave magnate from Louisiana was Antoine Dubuclet, who owned over 100 slaves. He had an estate worth \$264,000 in 1860 dollar value. This was in comparison with the wealth of White men of that time, averaging \$3,978."

William Ellison Jr. of South Carolina, a free man of color, was one of the wealthiest plantation owners in the state. He was the largest slave owner in his area, with 171 slaves, and over 900 acres of land producing massive amounts of tobacco. He donated large sums of money and foodstuffs to the Confederate Army, offered the military 53 of his slaves, and his mixed race grandson fought in the Confederate Army.

Many of the slave owners were born in bondage but were later freed and, through either inheritance, gifts, or work ethic, improved their situation, eventually moving into the profitable business of slavery. It was not uncommon for free African Americans to own slaves. Thousands did so. According to the 1860 census, only 1.4% white people owned slaves in 4.8% of southern slave states, but 28% of free African Americans in New Orleans owned slaves. McCluney wrote, "In South Carolina, where forty-three percent of the free African American families owned slaves, the average number of slaves held per owner was about six. Similarly, in Louisiana, forty percent of free African American families owned slaves, twenty-six percent of those in Mississippi held slaves, twenty-five percent of those in Alabama, and this was also true for twenty percent of those in Georgia."

Their wealth elevated the status of these slaveowners of color, gaining them status among the highest in the white community, intermingling with, socializing, even marrying (even when it was illegal), and becoming some of the most well-respected people in their community. McCluney wrote of Justus Angel, born a slave in South Carolina but who became "a wealthy Black master who lived in Colleton District, South Carolina, in 1830. Angel was a plantation owner who owned 84 slaves, a staggering number even for a Black master. He was a man of great wealth and influence, which allowed him to amass such a large number of enslaved individuals under his control." Of this wealthy planter class, he wrote, "These individuals often took steps to associate with the White elite, viewing themselves as an extension of this class. In doing so, the Black slaveowners were able to carve out a place for themselves within the ruling class." Then there is William Johnson in Mississippi, who:

"Became a successful entrepreneur with a barber-shop, bath house, bookstore, and land holdings. Though a former slave, in 1834 he would own three slaves and about 3,000 acres of property and would eventually own sixteen slaves before his death. He even hired out his slaves to haul coal and sand. Throughout his life, the white community in Natchez and Adams County held Johnson in high regard. He associated with and was close to many of Adams County's most prominent white families. Following Johnson's untimely death at the hands of a "free black, Baylor Winn, the Natchez Courier was moved to comment that Johnson held a "respected position [in the community] on account of his character, intelligence and deportment."

Further, McCluney argues that it was the common opinion of slaves that African American masters made

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Year of the Rat

Aea Varfis-van Warmelo · Granta

The smell of the crowd hits us before the sound does, a chemical tang from the hand-held flares sparking up in central Warsaw. It tickles our throats and itches our eyes. As we get closer to Solidarność Avenue, the capital's main street, the yells of 100,000 Polish demonstrators charge around the corner to meet us: Bóg! Honor! I Ojczyzna! God! Honour! And Fatherland!

Six of us are here from the UK. This rally is nominally meant to celebrate Polish independence on 11 November, but has become an annual meet-up for the European far right. Groups from across the Continent come to forge connections, sell copies of Mein Kampf, stamp on LGBT rainbow flags, and get drunk. Clad in skull balaclavas, they march through the city waving banners emblazoned with neo-Nazi symbols and slogans like 'DEFEND WHITE EUROPA'. Hosted for the last decade by a fascist party called the National Radical Camp, it has become a significant date in the extremist calendar. It is controversial even within Poland – the mayor of Warsaw has tried in previous years to ban it. Journalists reporting on the event have been attacked with mace by participants.

We are delegates from Britain First, an extreme political party run by Paul Golding. At the march, he points his camcorder at passing anti-abortion banners that depict bloody fetuses. 'This is how Britain should be,' Paul shouts over the noise. 'This is what a country without a left-wing ideology looks like – united and patriotic.'

The crowd moves east through the city, dodging fire-crackers and plumes of red and white flare smoke. Ashlea and Alex, two other Britain First members, look around in wonder. The biggest rallies they have attended back home had a fraction of this turnout. They marvel at the discipline of the crowd – their own events in the UK are beset by drunkards carrying beer cans and urinating in public.

Nick, a senior figure in the party, puts an excited arm around my shoulders and pats my chest. I tense up, feeling like I have been plugged into a socket. Nick's hand – not that he knows it – is touching the hidden camera underneath my shirt. Will he ask why a weird plastic box is taped to my chest? Will he expose my hidden wire in the middle of a mob of neo-Nazis? But he doesn't seem to notice, and we march on through Warsaw, my heart racing. Later, over dinner in a five-star hotel with a Polish MEP, I am convinced my camera is visible and keep dashing to the toilet to check. But I'm safe – for now.

We go out to a bar adorned with white pride stickers to down shots of frozen vodka. I listen to them talk about how the Holocaust was 'the big lie', and Auschwitz – a four-hour drive away – didn't have gas chambers, but swimming pools and cinemas for Jews to enjoy. When two of the guys suggest a strip club, I head back to my hotel, up the road from the Jewish cemetery of Warsaw which is filled with the mass

graves of ghetto victims. I lie on my bed with my hands on my face, smelling the booze and fag ash on my fingers, thinking about how much longer I'll be able to do this.

Britain First, who I was with in Poland, is one of the extreme groups I infiltrated.

Aea Varfis-van Warmelo

I was undercover in the British far right for more than a year, pretending to be a racist named Chris while feeding information back to my colleagues at HOPE not hate, an anti-fascist organisation. I put my normal life as a journalist on hold to spend time among racists. Britain First, who I was with in Poland, is one of the extreme groups I infiltrated. There was also a far-right community network, a white nationalist campaign, a neo-Nazi conference, a circle of Holocaust deniers, and a movement of race scientists, including one well-funded organisation financially backed by Silicon Valley.

Each of the groups had their own beliefs and attracted members for different reasons. Not one of them knew my real identity, although I repeatedly came close to being found out.

For a year, I was constantly frightened. It felt like there was an exclamation mark stamped onto my brain. Exposure was my biggest worry, and I imagined it happening in two ways. Either I would make a small but irreparable slip-up, like introducing myself as Harry instead of my fake name, Chris. Or I would be in a pub, wedged into a corner, when a friend from my normal life would approach shouting my real name and I would be unable to explain myself.

Before a meet-up, I thought about all the ways it could go wrong, obsessing over possible conversations and how to escape if the worst happened. An hour undercover required three or four to prepare. As a naturally nervous person, I found that my habit of mentally rehashing past conversations and planning future ones was helpful in preparing for undercover meetings. I would rehearse dialogue and try to anticipate potentially difficult questions about who I was, or why I wanted to know something. Afterwards, I would be unable to sit still, my fingers palpitating with a five-espresso jitter. Having kept myself steady for so long, I would have a lot of nervous energy to release. Every night after a meet-up, I had nightmares about being exposed.

I put myself through this because I wanted to get close to the British far right, find out what kind of people join, and, if possible, do what I could to disrupt their operations. The far right now makes up around a third of terrorism convictions and a majority of referrals to the government's Prevent counter-radicalisation scheme. The threat of terrorist activity was frequently in the headlines during this time. A man firebombed an immigration centre in Dover. A white supremacist from the Midlands made firearms and explosives to kill ethnic minorities and was convicted on terror-

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The Balloons That Went to War: Britain's Electrical Offensive Against Nazi Germany

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

At the beginning of the Second World War, Britain looked for ways to strike back that went beyond symbolism. The aim was practical effect. Anything capable of unsettling German industry, slowing production, or forcing resources into repair rather than manufacture was worth exploring. Bombing raids dominated headlines and memory, but elsewhere a quieter idea was taking form, one that required neither aircraft nor crews crossing enemy airspace. The idea involved balloons.

These were not barrage balloons hovering over British cities. They were free-flying hydrogen balloons, released into favorable winds and left to drift eastward across the North Sea. Suspended beneath them were long metal wires or small incendiary devices, intended not to destroy cities but to interfere with systems. Power. Communications. Rail signaling. The infrastructure that kept a modern industrial state functioning.

The concept did not emerge from theory alone. Before the war, stray balloons had already demonstrated an inconvenient reality. When metal cables became tangled with overhead power lines, the consequences could be immediate. Short circuits. Tripped substations. Widespread outages. Engineers disliked it. Military planners paid attention.

By 1941, pressure was growing to respond to German attacks without exposing more bomber crews to unacceptable losses. Unorthodox ideas were welcomed, provided they were inexpensive, repeatable, and scalable. It was with this requirement that Operation Outward took shape. It was low-tech by design, almost dismissively simple, and that simplicity made it difficult to counter.

A hydrogen balloon could be manufactured quickly and launched without specialized aircraft. Released under the right conditions, it might travel hundreds of miles. If it failed, little was lost. If it succeeded, the consequences could extend far beyond the point of contact.

Two main variants were used. One carried small incendiary devices, intended to ignite dry heathland, woodland, or agricultural areas. These fires were not expected to devastate cities, but even minor blazes demanded attention and manpower.

And a second variant carried a trailing wire. Often many tens of meters long, this cable was designed to snag high-voltage power lines. When it bridged conductors, it could short circuits and trip protective systems, taking sections of the network offline and sometimes damaging equipment. Repairs took time. In certain cases, specialized components were required, slowing recovery further.

Precision was never the goal. Those launching the balloons had no way of knowing where they would

land. That uncertainty was built into the strategy. Success depended on volume rather than accuracy.

By the Second World War, Landguard was already centuries old, its defenses layered with earlier conflicts. During the 1940s, it was adapted once again. Balloons were prepared, filled, and released when conditions allowed, drifting away over the North Sea toward occupied Europe.

The process was methodical rather than dramatic. Crews watched weather charts closely. Timing mattered. Released too low, balloons would fall short. Released too high, they might drift harmlessly past their intended regions.

For those living nearby, there was little to explain what was happening. A balloon rose, then disappeared. No aircraft followed. No explosions were heard. Only the quiet sense that something had been sent eastward.

Operation Outward operated mainly between 1942 and 1944. Over that period, tens of thousands of balloons were released. Estimates vary, but figures around 99,000 are commonly cited. This was not an experiment conducted once and abandoned. It was sustained.

The cost per balloon was low. Compared with the expense of a single bomber sortie, the contrast was stark. No crews were endangered. Losses were expected and accepted. German authorities could not intercept every drifting balloon, nor could they prevent the effects once one contacted infrastructure.

The precise impact of Operation Outward is difficult to quantify. Records are incomplete, and German wartime documentation tended to focus on larger threats. Even so, evidence suggests that trailing-wire balloons caused repeated electrical disruptions, particularly in rural and industrial areas dependent on overhead lines.

Operation Outward never captured public imagination in the way bombing campaigns or commando raids did, as there were no dramatic photographs, no returning crews, and no medals awarded for balloon launches. Wartime secrecy played a part, as did perception. Balloons felt faintly absurd compared to the machinery of modern war.

For Felixstowe, and for sites like Landguard Fort, Operation Outward represents a rarely acknowledged strand of wartime history. The town is more often associated with defense, ports, and coastal patrols. Its role as a launch point for a wind-driven offensive against German power networks is easily overlooked.

Operation Outward serves as a reminder that the Second World War was not fought solely with tanks and aircraft. It was also fought with patience, improvisation, and ideas that seemed improbable until they were put into practice.

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This should all be included when you buy a book.], [I love this idea. It's almost perfect. It has just one problem:

Paper costs money.

So I can't just include it for free.], [But following this philosophy, it's not right to charge full price for each paper book, because that would mean paying repeatedly for the contents!], [So here's the solution I came up with:], [Contents of my book: \$15], [Delivery of all digital formats: FREE], [Paper? Just cover its cost: \$4 each (+ postage)], [I like this.

It means you never pay for the contents twice.

It works out well for many different scenarios:], [All digital formats: \$15], [First paper book: \$19], [Paper books after you've bought the contents: \$4 each], [Loved the ebook, and now want to buy 20 paper copies for your friends? Just \$4 each, so \$80 total for 20 hardcover books .], [It's worked out well. People are buying many hardcover copies as gifts. A few people have bought over 500 copies each to give to clients or members of their organization.], [The only downside of creative pricing is it requires a little explanation. Like anything unusual.], [Log in to sivers.com to get my books. ©], [See my previous article on pricing philosophy for more thoughts on creative pricing .], [Read " Make a dream come true " for more thoughts on making things the way they should be .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 404, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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and how they act within it.*

TED Staff

standard-article(title: [Where we do and don't want automation], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([I used to use Gmail. But one day, as I typed my mother's email address into the "To:" field, Google popped up a prompt asking if I also wanted to CC my uncle. That was so invasive and creepy that I deleted the account immediately and never used it again. I don't want automated intelligence in my private email.], [My friend lives in a home full of the smartest technology, and loves getting all the new smart things, but he drives a deliberately retro old car with no computer chips. He loves to tinker with his car, and wants to do any maintenance himself.], [Another friend lives in a tech-free rustic cabin with no screens, but drives a Tesla.], [I do everything on a broken old Linux laptop, using only the command line, usually offline, nothing in the cloud. I think it's because I don't want any outside automation or intelligence in the work that matters to me.], [When software is described as "auto-", "smart", or "intelligent" it means that somebody else put their rules into it. But I don't want my computer to do anything I didn't explicitly tell it to do. It shouldn't change what I typed unless I tell it to. It should never guess or predict what I want.

I want full manual control.], [On the other hand, I don't mind if my phone does these things, because I don't care about my phone much. And I would love a high-tech car, full of smart AI automation, because I'm not a car aficionado.], [At first I thought that an expert at something won't want assistance. But no, of course, auto-pilot for airline pilots, and IDEs for programmers.], [So I think it comes down to:], [how much of an expert you are at controlling this thing yourself], [how much you still enjoy doing it], [if you want the kind of assistance it provides], [Any thoughts on this subject? I'd love to hear another point of view.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 331, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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standard-article(title: [Why I left America], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([I was living on the beach in Santa Monica, California, and life was perfect. I was in paradise, and deeply happy.], [Friends wanted to travel, but I had no interest. I had already lived a few years each in New York City, Boston, Chicago, Portland, and San Francisco. Santa Monica was perfect. I loved the weather, the people, the lifestyle, the business opportunities, and everything. It was the best place on earth.], [But I always want to learn and grow. To grow intellectually, you need to be surprised.

If we're not surprised, we're not really learning.

We may add new information, but not really update our understanding of the world. No "Wow!" No "Aha!"], [To keep learning and growing, we should always seek out new perspectives. Appreciate music, food, and experiences we initially dislike. Read about subjects we know nothing about. Understand people we disagree with. Take on new challenges. Avoid routine.], [I started feeling like my happiness and comfort — my feeling that things here are the way they should be — might make me stagnate, plateau, or atrophy.], [Yes I could have forced myself to learn and grow from home. But I'd be fighting the gravity that pulls me into my comfortable chair and routines.

I wanted an environment that forces me to grow.

Somewhere full of daily surprises, whether I seek them or not.], [So I forced myself to leave America. Leave my comfort zone. I considered finding new perspectives inside America, living in Texas, Louisiana, South Carolina, New Mexico, and Alaska. But why the artificial boundary? Why not Turkey, Nigeria, Finland, Indonesia, Israel, China, and Brazil?], [Places have a living philosophy. I wanted to understand these different approaches to life. I wanted them to also feel like home.], [So I set off into the world, with that goal.

Move to a place that feels strange, until it feels like home.

Constantly learning and growing. Then do it again, pursuing discomfort, until the whole world is my home.], [For another side to this story, read "Why I let go of my U. S. citizenship"].], [(This picture is from the movie "Big Fish", where at the beginning of the hero's journey, he finds a paradise, and everyone there begs him to stay, but he says, "I'm sorry, I may never find a place this nice again, but I need to go out into the world and have my adventure.")],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 405, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Your heroes show which way you're facing], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([People with many interests often

would fill a whole book. (Actually, four books so far, since that's what my previous books were about.) So instead, for your own ideation, it might help if I list the traits that my most useful perspectives have shared:], [Direct:

Go directly for what I really want, instead of using other means to get there. This requires soul-searching of my real motivations. What do I really want? And what's the point of that? Am I keeping a job just to feel secure? Getting a university degree for the status? Starting a business for the freedom? Instead, find a more efficient path to the real end result.], [Energizing:

I'll think of many smart but uninspiring perspectives, then one makes me bolt straight up in my seat, full of excitement. It inspires me to take immediate action. Note that fear is a form of excitement.], [Self-reliant:

It doesn't depend on anything out of my control. It doesn't need anyone's approval or involvement. It doesn't need anything to change. It works no matter what happens. It's about the process, not the outcome.], [Balancing:

Lately I've had too much of something, and not enough of something else. Comfort versus challenge. Social-time versus me-time. Exploring versus focusing. Prioritize what's been neglected.], [Selfless:

I see myself from the outside, and know that I basically don't matter. My needs are nothing compared to other people's, so how can I help? "Useful" means for them and the greater good.], [Selfish:

Generosity can go too far. Protect the goose that lays the golden eggs. Practice healthy self-respect and self-care that comes from self-worth.], [Lucid and lasting:

Coming from a good state of mind, not angry, hurt, envious, or upset — not even ecstatically happy. It's smart, and still seems like a good perspective a day or week later when I'm in a different state.], [Test first:

No matter how certain I feel, test an idea in reality. Before deciding, try it. Before buying something big, rent it, more than once. Before quitting, take a break.], [Healthy:

Do the right thing — do what's wise and good — even if I don't feel like it. Ask my idealized highest self how to think of this.], [Long-term:

In the big picture of my whole life, this is just a phase. Keep my eyes on the horizon. Short-term discomfort or pain can bring a deeply fulfilling reward. Serve the future.], [Compensating for bias and prejudice:

Correcting a bias, like my example of bowling and frisbee, earlier in this book. Do the opposite of my instincts. If I tend to walk away, I choose to stay. When I notice I'm prejudiced against something, I choose to get to know it and appreciate it. These have been the best beliefs for personal growth.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 467, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

ask my advice on which industry or career path they should follow.], [Years ago, I felt I was just a programmer and entrepreneur. Yes sometimes I write a tiny blog post sharing what I've learned, but that's just something on the side.], [But something never felt quite right about this. I spend most of my time writing, very little time programming, and hadn't started a business in years . Still, I kept saying I was a programmer and entrepreneur, and felt I should really spend more time doing it.], [But everything changed when I asked myself a question:], ["Who are my heroes?"], [I thought, wrote them down, then realized they were all authors ! Basically, look at my list of favorite books , and there are my heroes.], [The people I look up to the most... The people I'd most like to meet... The people I'd most like to emulate are not entrepreneurs, and not programmers — just writers.], [So, that day, I realized I actually want to be a writer.], [I re-arranged my hierarchy of interests. Yes I enjoy programming, and yes I'll probably start another business. But really my main love and top priority is writing.], [How about you? Who are your heroes? Does that help you see which way you're actually facing?],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 220, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

But something never felt quite right about this.

Derek Sivers

standard-article(title: [a relationship that ended, not failed], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([I was dating for the first time, after a six year long relationship.], [Someone asked, “Why did your last relationship fail?”], [I said, “It didn’t.”], [“OK then why didn’t it work out?”], [I said, “It did!”], [We’re not still together, but it was great from beginning to end .], [It started with an email. “Hi. My name is Anna. A happy girl in Sweden. You sound really interesting. Please tell me more about yourself.”], [I thought it was probably spam, but before deleting it, just in case, I replied “Who are you and why do you think I’m interesting?”], [She replied. I replied. She replied with more. I replied with more. Once a day, at the end of the day, a single email. Because we were strangers on the other side of the world, we got more and more honest, like a confession booth, saying the things we wouldn’t tell anyone else.], [After three months of emailing, we switched to real-time chat. After six months, for the first time, she sent me her photo. She was hot! I flew to Sweden and it was on.], [After two years of visiting each other, she moved to America to be with me. A year later, we got secretly married , only for immigration. She moved to Los Angeles for film school, so I moved with her.], [We got along so well, just happy to be together. In six years, we had only one fight, for about ten minutes, about whose turn it was to clean the bathroom. That was it. Six years of sweet romantic harmony.], [But our interests were pulling us in different directions. I wanted to spend more time working in Portland. She wanted to spend more time with her friends in LA that were single and having adventurous flings — an experience she’d never had.], [After a movie on the 3rd Street Promenade in Santa Monica, we sat on a bench having a lemonade, talking about this, then one of us said it first.], [“Do you want to break up?”], [“Yeah. Do you?”], [“Yeah. You’re not upset?”], [“Not at all. Are you hurt?”], [“No. Wow. We just broke up.”], [“Yeah. End of an era. So... now what?”], [Best breakup ever.

We walked home together, drinking our lemonades, sharing our plans for what we wanted to do next.], [We went to sleep in the same bed that night, but at 4am I woke up excited, packed my car, kissed her goodbye, and drove sixteen hours to Portland. I never saw her again. We only talked for a few minutes, later that year, to file the divorce stuff. Life moves on.], [Someone asked, “Why did your last relationship fail?”], [But it didn’t.

It was a great relationship, and was just what we needed.

I remember it fondly.], [A relationship, like a movie or book, doesn’t fail when it comes to an end.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 481, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Philosophies are instruments], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([Los Angeles, 1952. Igor Stravinsky, the composer, was 70 years old, and rehearsing the orchestra.], [A young girl who lived next to the orchestra hall snuck in through the back door to listen to the rehearsals. She watched the violins, cellos, flute, trumpet, clarinet, harp, percussion, and piano. She wondered which one should be her favorite. There were too many options. She needed to pick one. During a break, she got up the courage to ask the maestro.], [Stravinsky’s friend and writer Robert Craft was there, so that’s why this moment is captured.], [The young girl went up to Stravinsky and said, “Excuse me. Which of these instruments is the best one?” He was surprised and amused, and took the challenge.], [He said, “You hear sounds, but I hear life. Every instrument is a philosophy. Every philosophy is an instrument. ” She just looked at him, confused, so he continued.], [“You could pick just one instrument, one philosophy. But wouldn’t it be more interesting to play them all?”], [The girl said, “What?!? Nobody can play them all! How could I?”], [Stravinsky said, “Let’s say, as a young woman, you go out into the world to meet new people, full of multiculturalism and humanism. You do something daring, filled with optimism. Then you start a family and have time for nothing but pragmatism. You lose a loved one and comfort yourself with stoicism. But it makes no sense, so you’re drawn to existentialism. See? So many instruments!”], [The girl said, “What if I want to pick just one?”], [He said, “Most people do pick just one. They think their instrument is the best! Go ask anyone in this orchestra, and they’ll give you indisputable proof why their instrument is better than all others. You’ll never convince that cellist that the clarinet is better, so why try? Just like religions, cultures, and philosophies , right?”], [There was a long pause. The girl said, “So, which do you think is the best?”], [Stravinsky smiled and said, “Time.”], [“Time?”], [“Time! I can separate the instruments with time. Or I can combine them at the same time. Different instruments for different times in the music. Different philosophies for different times in your life. You can play every instrument, and every philosophy, if you use time, and combine. Time itself is my favorite instrument.”], [The girl seemed satisfied, and walked back to the balcony to listen again.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 401, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

“You could pick just one instrument, one philosophy.

Derek Sivers

standard-article(title: [Judge the contents, not the box], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([My cousin took a course on a complete system for physical fitness and health, and followed every bit of its advice. She had great results at first. But then she saw the coach's social media posts, and hated his political beliefs, so now she doesn't follow that course at all.], [A best-selling book on psychology is filled with wisdom that would improve your life, if applied. But a few sentences were found to be plagiarized, or some of its studies don't replicate. So people trash the whole book and refuse to read it.], [That's the problem with judging a box instead of its contents. It's seeking "true" instead of useful. When any aspect of a package is flawed, it no longer feels "true", so all of it is discarded. You lose all of the benefits.], [Think of a famous person you despise, perhaps a politician or celebrity that represents everything wrong with the world. Now imagine hearing that person say something you really like. Hard to imagine, right? You've probably pre-decided that anything that comes out of that person's mouth is going to be bad. No matter what they say, you're against it, in advance. Judging someone as good or bad, instead of each individual idea as useful or not.], [Listen to ideas, not their messenger. Focus on the contents, not the box. Avoid ideology.], [You've probably heard the phrase, "Perfect is the enemy of good." Likewise:

True is the enemy of useful.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 243, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Theme Switcher in Nginx], author: [Dennis Felsing], source-name: [Dennis Felsing], images: (), paragraphs: ([Thanks to xse we got a JavaScript based theme switcher . After some improvements I finally I switched it away from JavaScript entirely and finally am also using it on this blog with an OLED friendly dark theme.], [The final result is quite simple, and only requires static HTML, a cookie for the theme and Nginx for setting and returning the correct CSS file for it. You can try it out by clicking on the Switch Theme button at the top of this page, which just redirects you to /switch-theme/ .], [Doing the CSS decision server-side instead of in JavaScript has the advantage that you don't get any flicker on rendering, no matter what theme you chose.], [The entire nginx logic is:], [location /switch-theme/ { if (\$http_cookie * "user_theme=/public/css-dark.css") { add_header Set-Cookie "user_theme=/public/css-empty.css ; path=/ ; domain=hookrace.net" ; return 302 \$http_referer ; } add_header Set-Cookie "user_theme=/public/css-dark.css ; path=/ ; domain=hookrace.net" ; return 302 \$http_referer ; }], [location /public/css-dark.css { if (\$http_cookie * "user_theme=/public/css-dark.css") { return 302 /public/css/css-dark.css ; } return 302 /public/css/css-empty.css ; }], [Note that the /switch-theme/ location sends the user back to the \$http_referer . /public/css-dark.css is statically included on each page, but what it does depends on the cookie value.], [The 302 Moved Temporarily response makes the client send another request,

standard-article(title: [Fragments Dec 11], author: [Martin Fowler], source-name: [Martin Fowler], images: (), paragraphs: ([Why does AI write like... that (NYT, gift link). Sam Kriss delves into the quiet hum of AI writing. AI's work is not compelling prose: it's phantom text, ghostly scribbles, a spectre woven into our communal tapestry.], [* * * * *], [Emily Bache has written a set of Test Desiderata, building on some earlier writing from Kent Beck. She lists the characteristics of good tests, and how they support her four "macro desiderata" - the properties of a sound test suite], [Predict success in production], [Fast to get feedback], [Support ongoing code design change], [Low total cost of ownership], [She also has a great list of other writers' lists of good test characteristics.], [* * * * *], [Daphne Keller explains that the EU's fines on X aren't about free speech.], [There are three charges against X, which all stem from a multi-year investigation that was launched in 2023. One is about verification — X's blue checkmarks on user accounts — and two are about transparency. These charges have nothing to do with what content is on X, or what user speech the platform should or should not allow.], [* * * * *], [Cory Doctorow The Reverse-Centaur's Guide to Criticizing AI], [Start with what a reverse centaur is. In automation theory, a "centaur" is a person who is assisted by a machine. ... And obviously, a reverse centaur is machine head on a human body, a person who is serving as a squishy meat appendage for an uncaring machine.], [Like an Amazon delivery driver... the van can't drive itself and can't get a parcel from the curb to your porch. The driver is a peripheral for a van, and the van drives the driver, at superhuman speed, demanding superhuman endurance.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 292, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [You are the strange one], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([A traveler comes to a river and sees a local woman on the opposite bank. He yells across, "How do I get to the other side of the river?"], [She yells back, "You are on the other side of the river!"], [An American woman went on a vacation to Scotland. Talking with a group of people there, she said, "I just love your accent!"], [They said, "We don't have an accent. You do."], [For hundreds of years, people worshipped Zeus, Athena, Odin, and Thor. Now we call it mythology. But when it comes to our own beliefs? No no no! Those are just true! Only others' beliefs are myths and superstitions.], [You take some principles or values very seriously. You think of them as undeniable truths. But to other people, you are the one with silly beliefs.], [See yourself from the other side of the river. You have an accent.

Since you know other people's beliefs aren't true, you have to realize that yours are also not true.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 168, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

adding another roundtrip to the page rendering. If the CSS is small enough you can just pull it directly into the Nginx config:], [location /public/css-dark.css { if (\$http_cookie * "user_theme=/public/css-dark.css") { return 200 "body { color: #fff; background-color: #000;} .page-title, .post-title, .post-title a, h1, h2, h3, h4, h5, h6 {color: #ccc;} .mast-head-title a {color: #bbb;}"; } return 200 "" ; }], [One side effect of this entire approach is that the CSS file can't be cached anymore though, otherwise we'd end up showing the old theme when it gets switched. I'm sure this could be optimized somehow to tell the browser to only fetch the CSS file again after the theme was switched. But for my site the current performance is good enough.], [Also note that If Is Evil in Nginx, so if you abuse features like this you might run into trouble.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 392, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The first time I met someone who believes in God], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([My parents never mentioned God or any religion. Not necessarily atheist — nothing against. The subject just never came up.], [I grew up across the street from a Catholic church. (440 South Clay Street in Hinsdale, Illinois.) Like any temple of a religion you'd heard nothing about, it had no meaning to me.], [My best friend, Mark Hemstreet, lived next door. We were eleven years old, playing in the snow. I hit my hand on some ice and said, "God damn it.]", [He looked at me, surprised, and said, "You took the Lord's name in vain!]", [I said, "Wait, are you kidding or serious?]", [He said, "Serious!]", [I thought he was straight-face kidding.

I honestly didn't know anyone believed in God.

Because the subject had never come up, I thought God was just like Santa Claus. A sweet idea, but almost nobody over the age of eight actually literally believes it, right?], [I said, "Wait, so do you believe in the Easter Bunny and Tooth Fairy?]", [He looked scared and said, "Dude. This is serious.

If you don't believe in God, you're going to turn into a locust on Judgement Day.

They told us at Sunday School.]", [I laughed and said, "Oh really? Well if they've got all the facts, then what kind of locust will I be? Will I stay this same size, or shrink down? How does that work? What are the details?]", [He didn't answer but was really concerned for me, and said, "You can't joke about this stuff.]", [Because that was my introduction to religion, I used to find them ridiculous. But now, as an amateur anthropologist, I'm trying to understand them all. See my next post on this subject.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 287, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [A QOJ week], author: [Petr Mitrichev], source-name: [Petr Mitrichev (competitive programming)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Pinely Round 5 started the competitive part of the last week on Thursday (problems , results , top 5 on the left, analysis). This was my first individual appearance in a screenshot on this blog since April 2024 , so I think it went pretty well :) I was figuring out the solutions pretty quickly, and did not get stuck in implementation like I often do. However, it was not nearly good enough for the first place, since tourist was both the fastest, and with zero incorrect attempts. Congratulations on the convincing win!], [Problem F gave me a nice warm feeling when I figured out the solution, so maybe it will be enjoyable for you as well: you are given a tree with n], [The 4th Universal Cup Stage 4: Chengdu took place on Saturday, as usual (problems , results , top 5 on the left, analysis in Chinese). Team USA1 won the third stage out of four this year, defying the parity rule. The second place went to a team that is not in the season rating , so I assume this was a team that was participating in the original onsite contest that this stage was a mirror of. Congratulations to both teams on solving all problems!], [Yandex Cup 2025 Qualification Round wrapped up the week on Sunday (results , top 5 on the left). A few people were in contention on the easier problems, but starting from problem J ecnerwala was significantly faster than the competition, so it is not a surprise that only he was able to solve everything this time. Well done!], [After the 3rd Universal Cup Semifinals , this was the second big contest that required proctoring for those who want to qualify to the onsite round, and it was certainly not the last one to do so.], [In my previous summary , I have mentioned an AtCoder problem : you are given a single integer n], [I was discussing an old Open Cup gem with my friends recently, motivated by a lecture on binary search for beginner Swiss high school students. I was almost certain there is no way to upsolve that problem now. However, it turns out that this problem (and probably many other old Open Cup contests?) are now available for upsolving on QOJ.ac , the same website that hosts Universal Cup. Huge thanks to the admins of QOJ for preserving the old contests!], [Thanks for reading, and check back next week!],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 431, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [How many pets do you have?], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([I used to have too many pets.], [Each time I adopted one, I was fully in love. I was enamored with the potential. Each new pet was meant to be my constant companion. So I would take it home, and love it. But eventually I would discover a new pet, and the process would repeat.], [My house was overflowing. But it didn't feel that way at the time. In each moment, I was giving just one pet my full attention. My life was full of so many loves.], [Ah, but that's seeing it from my point of view. What about from theirs? Each pet only got a little of my time each week. The rest of the time they were neglected, waiting for my attention.], [I sadly realized this was unfair. The situation was hurting them. No pet was thriving. No pet was getting the attention it deserved. The situation was also hurting me. Anyone who wanted to come into my life had to compete for my attention, or love all of my pets. I was scattered and unavailable.], [So, I started releasing them back into the wild. One at a time, reluctantly, I'd set one free, or find it a new home with someone who was really going to give this pet 100% of their love. I mourned the loss of possibility with each one as I said goodbye.], [My pet project to start a business.], [My plan to travel everywhere.], [My dream to learn Chinese.], [My goal to plant a forest.], [My wish to build a house.], [Although each goodbye was sad, it opened up more space. I enjoyed the freedom and feeling unconflicted.], [Before, I'd glance at each pet and feel love but guilt for not giving it more time. Now, I picture what could have been, and just enjoy the daydream.], [I let my last pet go, came home, and cleaned the house. There's so much room for focus now.], [Surprising end to this story: One pet kept coming back, no matter how many times I set her free. She refused to stay away. So now it's just me and her, and I'm giving her all my time.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 362, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Anti-chameleon], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([I don't know why I have this rebellious nature. I tend to want to be the opposite of my surroundings.], [At serious formal events, I can't stop laughing inside. At crazy festivals, I want to hide and read a book.], [My ambitious friends bring out the slacker in me. My lethargic friends make me feel like superman.], [When I moved to Boston, as a teen, and everyone was wearing black, I dressed in only white. I remind new-agey people of the scientific method.], [Is it a desire for balance? To represent what seems under-represented in this situation? Is it my love of seeing the other side?], [I hear I'm not supposed to react like this. I'm supposed to be the same, no matter what's around.], [But I'm not the same from day to day, even when alone. I rebel against myself, too. If I've been thinking or acting one way for too long, I try another way.], [It's worked pretty well for me so far.

I'm super-motivated by the horror of seeing the opposite of what I want.], [Seeing someone waste their talent motivates me to get back to practicing and creating.], [Seeing a person in horrible health motivates me to be healthy.], [Seeing someone freaking out motivates me to be calm.], [Seeing someone being selfish motivates me to be generous.], [The list goes on. It's been net positive. So, I'm not fighting it for now.], [(P. S. I'll never argue against preserving nature.)],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 255, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

Anyone who wanted to come into my life had to compete for my attention, or love all of my pets.

Derek Sivers

But I'm not the same from day to day, even when alone.

Derek Sivers

standard-article(title: [Two Poems], author: [Aea Varfis-van Warmelo], source-name: [Granta], images: (), paragraphs: ([Portrait of B. D. as a Man], [after Nicole Eisenman], [and now you are no], [-thing. Two dollars &], [twenty seven cents in a sock], [down the back of your head], [-rest. Every day's a fag], [your father gave you], [in the car with a wink], [& a don't tell your ma .], [You wake, late, face], [a smack on the black], [-out window. Film yourself], [in bed seven hours. Edit], [in a six minute special], [to send to Cannes. Smoke], [a joint. Kick a ball. Kill], [a bit of time flicking your], [wrist this way and that.], [Roll over & dream], [you're a girl— her loaded], [legs, baseball cap, animal], [smell of cunt tracking], [her all up the north-block], [& most the way back.], [Sonnet for a lost friend], [in my mouth like a

standard-article(title: [Keep tuning and adjusting], author: [Derek Sivers], source-name: [Derek Sivers], images: (), paragraphs: ([When I got my first guitar, the nice man at the shop put on new strings and tuned it. A week later, I brought it back to the shop because it sounded terrible. He told me it was just out of tune. I said, "But you tuned it already!" He explained that I constantly have to re-tune it every time I play.], [Same with adopting a new mindset. Every week, back in the journal, reflecting, talking with friends, and making adjustments.], [Sometimes you need to stick to the plan exactly, and only adjust your thoughts. Sometimes you need to update the plan. Use your wisdom to decide.], [Don't be discouraged when you get off course. A big benefit of keeping a journal is that you can go back and review it , to

blue crystal. I met four men at a party], [and told them my new name. That's gorge , they said in unison], [as if they, too, were united under a single name. I talked to them], [for a few more negronis before I realised they were there to talk], [to each other and I was merely incidental to this plan. The friend], [who threw the party had lengthy, hot-girl hair. She hung various things], [from it, like leaves and deep purple rays of light. I, too, wanted], [to be collapsable, like those foldable spoons you get on planes,], [but I was rigid. It was my nature. I thought changing my name], [would allow me to escape the violence of being given a name], [in the first place. On the walk back, my new and old names], [hung about, I heard them called from windows, I saw them], [written on street signs, pressed tight, as if they knew each other.], [Image © Europeana], [The post Two Poems appeared first on Granta .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 321, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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remind yourself what you're doing and why.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 140, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

How to make the best possible translation of a book?

Derek Sivers

You know that frustration of reading a book that should have been an article? Me too. So I try to do the opposite — to write so succinctly that you wish I would have said a little more. You complete it with your own thoughts.

That's why I edit the hell out of my writing. I delete every unnecessary sentence and word, then craft the few that remain. It takes more time for me, but saves time for everyone else. Hopefully this approach, where you fill my gaps with your own examples, is more powerful and effective. Maybe, as a side-effect, even more beautiful.

But then how should I approach its translation?

I'm willing to spend time and money to help make the best possible translations into Chinese, Spanish, Portuguese, and French. Maybe other languages, too, based on the potential audience. My books have been the primary creations of my life, and will be what's left of me after I'm dead, so I'd like to help make great translations of them while I'm here.

They're not poetry, but I put the same care into rhythm, structure, and even sound of the words. I can't just crap out a computer-generated translation, or under-pay an over-worked translator. I could hire one expensive translator, and that person could do one interpretation, but then what if it's too uniquely biased?

You've heard of The Wisdom of Crowds? The collected ideas of many people can be better than any one person's ideas. It doesn't apply to everything, but might apply to translations.

I built a tool for translators, reviewers, and editors, called Inchword .

It lets anyone suggest translation improvements, even if they have just a few minutes or hours to improve a few words or chapters. Editors review and approve those suggestions. Reviewers read the finished chapters. All of these people can ask me questions for clarification. And at some point, multiple people agree that it's as good as can be, and I mark the translation as finished. It's the "official author-approved translation." (What to do with it after that is a different issue.)

I'm not sure this is the best plan, so I'm open to suggestions. Please leave a reply, below, with any ideas.

Or if you can help as a translator, reviewer, or editor, please email me .

P. S. For the past few years I've licensed to foreign publishers who do their own translations , and nothing wrong with that, but I'd rather collaborate more closely with the translators to make sure each translation is the best it can be.

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ANALYSIS

IN BRIEF

Matt Castle, Damn Interesting: The Ancient Order of Bali :

In the 1970s, the Indonesian island of Bali went through a period of rapid change. Along the stunning beaches on the southern side of the island, tourism boomed. Parking lots were put up, together with swinging hot spots and hotels of various colours. Hip young travellers from North America, Europe, and Australasia had “discovered” the [...]

Martin Fowler, Martin Fowler: Rahul Garg continues his series of Patterns for Reducing Friction in AI-Assisted Development . This pattern describes a structured conversation that mirrors whiteboarding with a human pair: progressive levels of design alignment before any code, reducing cognitive load, and catching misunderstandings at the cheapest possible moment.

more...

Martin Fowler, Martin Fowler: Rahul Garg has observed a frustration loop when working with AI coding assistants - lots of code generated, but needs lots of fixing. He’s noticed five patterns that help improve the interaction with the LLM, and describes the first of these : priming the LLM with knowledge about the codebase and preferred coding patterns.

more...

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